Focus Is Your Superpower

Beat Procrastination, Escape Digital Distractions, and Get More Done Without Burning Out

Muhammad Waqas

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Focus Is Your Superpower: Beat Procrastination, Escape Digital Distractions, and Get More Done Without Burning Out

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Sana, Daniel, Amira and Tariq, and the other people whose stories run through this book, are composites. Each is built from situations that students, employees, freelancers and parents describe again and again, but none of them is a real person, and any resemblance to someone you know is a sign of how common these struggles are.

The research described in this book is summarized in plain language. Where a study is mentioned, the Notes and sources section at the back says where to find it.

This book offers general information about attention, habits and planning. It is not medical or psychological advice. If you have persistent trouble concentrating, low mood, anxiety, or experiences such as seeing or hearing things that other people do not, please speak to a doctor or a qualified mental health professional.

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For everyone who has opened a book, a laptop or a notebook and promised themselves, this time, they would finish.

Start here: how to use this book

You do not have to read this book from the first page to the last, although you can. It was written for people who are short on time and attention, which means it should be easy to dip into.

Every chapter does four things. It explains one problem in plain language. It shows the problem in a real-feeling life: a student, a manager, a freelancer or a father learning a new trade at night. It gives you one or more techniques to try. And it ends with a short section called “Try this today”, which you can do in less than half an hour, usually much less.

If you read a chapter and skip the exercise, you will understand your habits a little better. If you do the exercise, you will start to change them. The second is the point.

The people you will meet

Four people appear throughout the book. They are composites, built from the stories that come up whenever people talk honestly about distraction.

Sana is twenty and in her second year of a pharmacy degree. She is bright and she cares about her grades. She also loses two or three hours a day to short videos without ever deciding to, and she does most of her studying in a panic the week before each exam.

Daniel is thirty-four and manages projects for a logistics company. Since his team went remote, he works from a desk in the corner of his bedroom. He is busy from eight in the morning until seven at night, and he cannot remember the last day he finished the thing he meant to finish.

Amira is twenty-eight and works for herself as a graphic designer. She also sells prints through a small online shop. She is talented and a perfectionist, and she puts off any task where she might be judged: proposals, pricing emails, posting her work.

Tariq is forty-five, an accountant with two teenagers, and he is teaching himself to code so he can change careers. He has the motivation. What he lacks is energy after nine hours at work, and a way to stop imagining the new life long enough to build it.

You may see yourself in one of them, or in pieces of all four.

The FOCUS method

The techniques in this book fit into five steps. Their first letters spell FOCUS, which makes them easy to remember on a bad day.

F: Find what matters. Decide which goals and tasks deserve your best attention, and which ones can wait or be dropped.

O: Organize your time. Give important work a place in your calendar, sized realistically, with room for the things that will go wrong.

C: Control distractions. Change your phone, your room and your routines so that the easy thing and the right thing are more often the same thing.

U: Use your energy wisely. Work with your body and mind, with sleep, breaks and the hours when you think best, instead of

against them.

S: Sustain your progress. Build habits, review your week and recover quickly when things slip, because they will.

FOCUS is a way of organizing well-known methods, not a new scientific theory. Its value is that it tells you where to look when something is not working. If your days are full but nothing important moves, the problem is usually F or O. If you know what to do and keep drifting to your phone, start with C. If you start strong and fade by mid-week, look at U and S.

A two-minute focus check

Answer these three questions quickly. Pick the answer that is most often true for you.

1. What most often stops you from finishing important work?

a. I keep checking my phone or drifting to websites and videos.
b. I worry, overthink, or put off starting.
c. I have too many tasks and no clear priorities.
d. I start well but run out of energy or consistency.

2. What usually happens when you sit down to work?

a. Within minutes, I'm on something else.
b. The task feels too big, too vague or too uncomfortable.
c. I'm not sure what to do first, so I do something small and easy.
d. I work, but I can't keep the routine going for more than a few days.

3. Which change would help you most?

a. Controlling my screen time.

b. Facing difficult tasks instead of avoiding them.

c. A realistic daily plan.

d. Steady habits and enough rest.

Count your letters. This is not a clinical test. It is a way to find a sensible starting point.

Mostly a: digital distraction. Read the introduction, then go to Chapters 3, 6 and 7.

Mostly b: avoidance and overthinking. Start with Chapters 2, 4 and 11.

Mostly c: planning and priorities. Start with Chapters 9, 10 and 14.

Mostly d: energy and consistency. Start with Chapters 12, 15, 16 and 17.

If your answers are spread out, read the book in order. It was built to work that way.

The 30-day challenge

At the back of the book is a 30-day challenge: one small exercise a day for a month, grouped into four weeks. Each day refers to the chapter that explains it. Some readers prefer to read the whole book first and then do the challenge. Others start the challenge on the day they open the book and read the chapters as they go. Both work.

You will also find a toolkit of planning pages and worksheets. Copy them into a notebook, or use them on paper if you have the paper-

back. They are deliberately simple. A plan you will use is better than a beautiful one you won't.

One request

Keep a notebook, paper or digital, while you read. Many exercises ask you to write something down, and writing is part of how they work. A thought you only think is easy to forget or argue with. A sentence you write down stays put and can be checked tomorrow.

Introduction: the life you keep postponing

It is 9:40 on a Tuesday night, and Sana has just opened her pharmacology notes. She has a test on Friday. She has told herself, out loud, that she will study until midnight.

At 9:43 her phone buzzes. A friend has sent a video of a cat falling into a bathtub. It is funny, so she watches it twice, and then the app shows her another, and another. Somewhere in there she replies to a group chat about weekend plans, looks up a celebrity she half-recognized in one of the clips, and reads the comments under a post about a skincare product she does not own. When she looks up, it is 11:15. Her notes are still open on the same page. She feels a small, sick drop in her stomach, and then, because she is tired and the feeling is unpleasant, she picks the phone back up.

Two time zones away, Daniel is finishing a day that began at 7:50 a.m. He has attended five video meetings, answered around ninety emails, approved a budget, chased a supplier and helped his son find a missing shoe. He has been busy for eleven hours. The project plan he promised his director by Thursday, the one piece of work that would actually move his career forward, is a blank document with a title.

Neither of them is lazy. Neither of them is stupid. Both of them would tell you exactly what they should be doing. And both of

them will go to bed with the same quiet feeling of having lost a day they cannot get back.

If you picked up this book, you probably know that feeling too.

Knowing, wanting and doing

Most of us do not lack information about what to do. We know that the assignment is due, that the business needs a website, that the report is more important than the inbox, that the phone is eating our evenings. We want to do better. We set goals, buy planners, download apps, watch videos about morning routines.

And then the ordinary day arrives, with its notifications and its tiredness and its small, reasonable-looking choices, and the gap between knowing, wanting and doing stays where it was.

This book is about closing that gap. It will not do it with motivation, because motivation is unreliable. It comes and goes with your mood, your sleep and the weather. It will do it with a system: a set of habits and small structures that make useful action more likely on the days you feel good and still possible on the days you don't.

The cost you can't see

A wasted evening rarely feels like a disaster. That is exactly what makes it dangerous.

If you lost a thousand dollars in one afternoon, you would notice. You would remember the day, think about how it happened and probably change something. Lose two hours a day to drifting, scrolling and half-working, and nothing dramatic happens. There is no single moment to regret. Each choice looks harmless: one more video, one more check of the inbox, one more day to think about starting.

Add it up, though. Two hours a day is fourteen hours a week. Over a year it comes to more than seven hundred hours, which is roughly eighteen full-time working weeks. That is enough time to learn the basics of a language, write the first draft of a book, finish a professional qualification, or build a small business on the side. Nobody gets all of those hours back, and nobody should try to. Rest and fun belong in a good life. But even reclaiming a third of them would change what a year can hold.

The real risk is not the occasional lost evening. Everyone has those. The risk is a slow slide in which distraction becomes the default and focused work becomes the exception, something you do only under the pressure of a deadline.

Why trying harder doesn't work

When people decide to fix their focus, they usually reach for willpower. They promise to try harder, to stop being weak, to just put the phone down. It rarely lasts more than a few days.

There are good reasons for that, and you will meet them in the first part of this book. Procrastination is mostly about avoiding uncomfortable feelings, not about poor time management. The apps on your phone are designed by teams of skilled people whose job is to keep you on them. Your mind wanders on its own for a large share of your waking hours. And a vague plan ("study tonight") gives your attention a hundred ways to slip.

None of this means you are helpless. It means the fight is not a fair one if you treat it as a contest of willpower. You need to change the terms: what is in front of you, what you have decided in advance, how big the first step is, and how you treat yourself when you slip.

Productivity is not the same as busyness

One more thing before we start, because it shapes everything that follows.

Being productive does not mean filling every hour with work. Daniel's eleven-hour day was full and almost entirely unproductive in the way that mattered to him. A student who studies in a focused way for three hours may learn more than one who sits at a desk for eight with the phone face-up beside the textbook.

Rest is not the enemy of achievement either. Sleep, exercise, meals with family, prayer or reflection, a long walk, an evening with friends: these are not failures of discipline. They are part of a life that can keep going. A system that only works if you give up everything else will not survive a month.

So when this book talks about productivity, it means something specific: putting your best attention and energy into the things that matter most to you, and protecting your well-being while you do it. Working on purpose, not working all the time.

What you'll learn

The book has five parts.

Part One explains why your attention keeps slipping: the emotional roots of procrastination, the way social media and smartphones capture attention, and the overthinking and daydreaming that pull you out of the present.

Part Two is about taking your attention back. You will train your focus in short, growing sessions, reset your relationship with your phone, design a room and a desk that help you work, and learn to protect long blocks of single-tasking.

Part Three turns to time. You will choose what matters using simple tools like the urgent-important matrix and the 80/20 rule, plan days that survive contact with reality, start tasks before you feel ready, and use work sessions and breaks that suit your mind.

Part Four deals with keeping going when motivation fades: goals you can act on, discipline without self-punishment, habits that carry you on bad days, and the sleep, movement and rest that make focus possible.

Part Five applies all of it to real situations: studying, working in an office or from home, running a business, and building a weekly routine you can keep for years.

After that comes the 30-day focus challenge, a toolkit of planning pages, and notes on the research.

A promise, and its limits

Here is what this book can promise. If you try the techniques honestly, most of them will help, some of them a great deal. You will understand why you avoid certain tasks. You will spend less time on things you didn't choose. You will finish more of what you start.

Here is what it can't promise. Thirty days will not turn you into a completely different person. Habits take longer than that to settle, and people differ. Some techniques that work wonderfully for one reader will do nothing for another. That is why the book treats every method as an experiment: try it, watch what happens, keep what works and drop the rest.

If you have tried everything and still find it very hard to concentrate, more than most people around you and for as long as you can remember, it may be worth talking to a doctor about condi-

tions such as ADHD, depression or anxiety, which can all affect attention. There is no shame in that. A good system and the right support can work together.

Before you turn the page

Think of one important thing you have been postponing. A course you keep meaning to finish. A business idea. A difficult conversation. A book. Your health. A skill you have wanted to learn for years.

Now ask yourself honestly: *What will happen if I keep postponing this for another year?*

Then ask a different question: *What might be possible if I took one small, real step toward it every day?*

You don't need to know where the road ends. You only need to stop treating the beginning as something that belongs to tomorrow.

Your goals don't need another promise. They need a place in today.

Let's begin.

Part One: Why your attention keeps slipping

Before you can fix a problem, you need to see it clearly. These four chapters look at what is really going on when you drift, delay and overthink.

Chapter 1: Busy is not the same as productive

On Wednesday morning, Daniel tried an experiment his sister had suggested. Every time he switched from one thing to another, he made a tally mark on a sticky note beside his keyboard. Email to spreadsheet: one mark. Spreadsheet to a message from a colleague: another. Message to the news site he opened without noticing: another.

By lunch, the sticky note was full. He counted eighty-one switches in just under four hours. That is one every three minutes or so. He had not spent more than ten minutes in a row on any single piece of work all morning, and yet, when his wife asked him over lunch how it was going, he said, truthfully, “Flat out. I haven’t stopped.”

He hadn’t. That was the problem.

Two people, one project

Picture two people given the same project and the same day.

The first starts early. She opens her email, then a few browser tabs she’ll need later, then the team chat. She answers questions as they come in, joins a meeting she wasn’t sure she needed to attend, and works on the project in the gaps. She switches often and thinks of herself as responsive. At six o’clock she has worked for ten hours and feels exhausted.

The second starts by asking one question: *What would make today a success?* She decides it is finishing the first full draft of the project's budget. She spends the first ninety minutes on that and nothing else, with her chat closed and her phone in a drawer. Then she answers messages in one batch, attends the one meeting that needs her, and spends another hour on the draft in the afternoon. She finishes at five.

The second person worked fewer hours. She also, very likely, got more of what mattered done.

The difference between them is not intelligence, talent or even motivation. It's where their attention went, and how often it was pulled somewhere else.

Attention is the resource you actually spend

We talk about managing time, but time is the easy part. Everyone gets the same twenty-four hours, and the clock runs whether you're using them well or not. What you actually have to manage is attention: which of the thousands of things around you, and inside you, gets your mind at any given moment.

Attention decides what you notice, what you learn, what you remember and what you produce. You can own the best laptop in the world and have access to every textbook ever written, but if your attention keeps sliding off the page, none of it helps much.

And attention has limits. Your brain can do many simple things at once (walk, chew gum, hum a song) because those tasks are automatic. It cannot do two demanding, thinking tasks at the same time in the way a computer runs two programs. When you try, it switches between them, back and forth, and each switch costs something.

The myth of multitasking

Multitasking feels efficient. You reply to a message while reading a report, half-watch a lecture while answering email, listen to a podcast while writing. There's a pleasant sense of keeping several plates spinning.

For simple tasks, combining them is fine. Folding laundry with music on is a perfectly good use of an evening. For demanding work, the research has been fairly consistent for more than twenty years. In a well-known set of experiments published in 2001, Joshua Rubinstein, David Meyer and Jeffrey Evans had people switch between different kinds of tasks and measured how long the switches took. Every switch cost time, and the cost grew as the tasks got more complex. The losses were fractions of a second per switch, but they add up when you switch hundreds of times a day, and they don't include the larger cost of losing your train of thought.

In 2009, researchers at Stanford compared people who described themselves as heavy media multitaskers with people who rarely multitasked. You might expect the heavy multitaskers to be better at it, through practice. They weren't. On several tests, they were more easily distracted by irrelevant information and slower to switch between tasks than the light multitaskers.

None of this means you're doomed to fail if you ever do two things at once. It means that when a task needs real thought, doing it alone is not a luxury. It's how the work gets done well.

What an interruption really costs

Think about writing something that matters: an essay, a proposal, a careful email to a client. You read the paragraph you wrote, you

begin to form the next idea, you can almost see where the argument is going. Then a notification appears. You glance at it. It's nothing urgent, so you go back.

But where were you? You reread the paragraph. You try to recall the idea that was forming. Some of it comes back. Some of it doesn't. The interruption lasted five seconds; the recovery took two minutes, and the idea you return to is a little flatter than the one you lost.

Gloria Mark, a researcher at the University of California, Irvine, has studied interruptions at work for decades. In one experiment, people who were interrupted while writing emails finished just as fast as those who weren't, and sometimes faster. They compensated by working quicker. But they reported significantly more stress, frustration, time pressure and effort. Interrupted work can look fine from the outside and feel much worse from the inside. Over a long day, that strain is a big part of why you feel drained without knowing what you've done.

There's a second cost too, which you'll meet properly in Chapter 8. When you switch away from an unfinished task, part of your attention stays behind with it. You're answering the message, but some of your mind is still on the essay, and when you return to the essay, some of it is still on the message.

The three kinds of distraction

To fix a problem, it helps to name it. For the rest of this book, it's useful to sort distractions into three kinds.

External distractions come from outside you. Notifications, phone calls, a colleague's question, the television in the next room,

a child who needs a snack, a messy desk, a browser full of open tabs.

Internal distractions come from inside. Boredom, worry, hunger, tiredness, a sudden memory of something you forgot to do, a daydream about the holiday you're planning, the itch to check whether anyone liked your post, the vague dread of a task that feels too hard.

Structural distractions come from how your life and work are arranged. Unclear priorities. A to-do list with forty items on it. Being expected to answer messages within minutes. Too many commitments. A calendar with no empty space. A workspace where the bed, the television and the desk share one corner.

Each kind needs a different fix. External distractions usually need changes to your environment: a quieter place, notifications off, the phone in another room. Internal distractions need emotional skills: noticing what you're feeling, tolerating some discomfort, knowing what to do with a wandering thought. Structural distractions need planning, boundaries and sometimes the courage to drop commitments.

No single app or motivational quote solves all three. That's why a real focus system has to deal with your surroundings, your inner life and the way your work is organized, which is what the rest of this book does.

Busy is a feeling, productive is a result

Here's a simple test. At the end of a day, ask two questions.

How busy was I? That one's about how the day felt. It's measured in effort, rushing and fatigue.

What did I finish that matters? That one's about results. It's measured in things that are now done, learned or moved forward.

Most people who struggle with focus score high on the first question and low on the second. They mistake the feeling of busyness for evidence of progress. It's an easy mistake to make, because busyness is loud and progress is often quiet. Answering twenty emails feels like twenty things done. Spending an hour thinking through a hard problem can feel like nothing happened at all, until you notice that the problem is solved.

Learning to tell the difference is the first skill in this book. Once you see it, you will start noticing the moments where you choose busy over productive, and you can begin to choose differently.

Decide before you begin

Many people sit down to work without deciding what they mean to do. They're going to "study", "work on the project", "do some writing". These intentions sound reasonable, but they're too vague to steer by. A vague task gives your mind dozens of possible directions, and when the work gets hard, it takes the easiest one, which is often away from the work altogether.

Compare these two plans.

"I'll study chemistry tonight."

"From 8:00 to 8:40, I'll do the five practice problems on chemical equilibrium at the end of Chapter 6, check my answers against the key, and mark any I got wrong."

The second plan has a start time, a scope and a finish line. Even if the problems are hard, you always know what the next action is.

When your attention drifts, you have something specific to come back to.

This is the first rule of focused work, and you'll see it again throughout the book:

Before you begin an important work session, decide what finishing that session will look like.

It takes thirty seconds. It changes the whole session.

Daniel's first change

Daniel didn't try to fix everything at once. After his sticky-note morning, he made one change. Each evening, before closing his laptop, he wrote a single sentence on a card: the one piece of work that would make tomorrow a good day. The next morning, before opening his email, he spent forty-five minutes on that sentence and nothing else.

The first two days were hard. He kept reaching for the email tab out of habit, and twice he opened it before he'd noticed what his hand was doing. By the end of the first week, he had a complete draft of the project plan that had sat untouched for a month. He had not worked longer hours. He had simply given forty-five minutes a day to one thing.

"It was a bit embarrassing, honestly," he said later. "I'd spent weeks thinking I didn't have time for it. I had the time. I was just spending it on everything else."

Try this today

Run your first focus experiment. It takes about forty minutes, including the notes.

1. Choose one meaningful task, something that matters and that you've been putting off or doing badly.
2. Write down the smallest useful result you could get in twenty-five minutes. Be specific: "outline the three sections of the report", not "work on the report".
3. Put your phone out of sight and reach, ideally in another room. If you can't, turn it face down and switch on a focus or do-not-disturb mode.
4. Close every browser tab and app you don't need for this task.
5. Set a timer for twenty-five minutes.
6. Work only on the chosen task. If another thought or task pops into your head ("I need to email Sara", "what time is the dentist?"), write it on a piece of paper in three or four words and go straight back to work.
7. When the timer ends, stop and answer four questions in your notebook:
    - Did I reach the result I wrote down?
    - What pulled at my attention?
    - At what point did I most want to switch to something else?
    - What one change would make the next session easier?

This isn't a test of your character. You're not trying to prove you have iron discipline. You're collecting evidence about how your attention behaves and what conditions help it.

Reflection

Before you go on to the next chapter, write short answers to these:

- Which activity eats most of the time I mean to spend working or studying?

- Which kind of distraction affects me most: external, internal or structural?
- What is one change I can make before my next focused work session?

Don’t try to solve everything today. Pick one change and test it. Focus improves when good intentions become small, repeatable actions.

Chapter 2: Why you put things off

Amira had a proposal to write. A small architecture firm had seen her work and asked for a quote to redesign their brand: logo, website graphics, a brochure. It was the biggest job she'd ever been offered. It was exactly what she'd been hoping for.

She didn't start it for nine days.

In those nine days she reorganized her design files into new folders. She cleaned her flat. She posted three times on her shop's account, answered every customer message within the hour, and watched most of a documentary about typography that she told herself counted as research. Every evening she opened a blank document titled "Proposal", looked at it for a minute, and closed it.

If you had asked her why, she would have said she was busy. If you'd pushed, she would have said she was lazy. Neither answer was true. She was working hard all week, just not on the proposal. And lazy people don't reorganize their file folders.

What was happening was something much more ordinary and much more human. The proposal made her feel bad, and avoiding it made the bad feeling go away for a while.

It's about feelings, not time

For a long time, procrastination was treated as a time-management problem. If you put things off, the thinking went, you needed

a better calendar, a sharper to-do list or more discipline.

Researchers who study procrastination now see it differently. Fuschia Sirois and Timothy Pychyl, two of the best-known names in the field, have argued that procrastination is mainly about mood. When a task stirs up an unpleasant feeling, such as boredom, anxiety, confusion, self-doubt or resentment, putting it off gives instant relief. You switch to something easier and the feeling fades. Your mood improves now, and the cost lands on your future self, who inherits the same task with less time to do it.

In their words, procrastination puts short-term mood repair ahead of long-term goals. The brain is choosing to feel better right now.

That is why procrastination so often looks like productivity. Amira wasn't lying on the sofa. She was doing things that felt useful, because useful-feeling activities give you relief from the avoided task without the guilt of doing nothing. Researchers sometimes call this productive procrastination. Cleaning the kitchen, answering easy emails, organizing your notes, buying new stationery: these are all ways of keeping busy near a task without touching it.

You are not alone

Procrastination is extremely common. In a large review published in 2007, the psychologist Piers Steel brought together hundreds of studies. He reported estimates that 80 to 95 percent of college students procrastinate, and that around half do it consistently and in ways that cause them problems. Among adults in general, a smaller but still large share describe themselves as chronic procrastinators.

So if you put things off, you're in very large company. The point of mentioning this isn't to excuse it, but to take away the idea that you're uniquely weak. You are a normal human being with a normal human tendency, and normal tendencies can be managed with the right tools.

What delay actually costs

Delay can look harmless in the short term. In one study from the 1990s, Dianne Tice and Roy Baumeister followed university students through a term. Early on, the procrastinators reported less stress than everyone else. They were, after all, not doing the work. By the end of the term the picture had reversed: the procrastinators were more stressed, reported more illness, and earned lower grades.

That pattern is worth remembering. Procrastination is a loan. It feels good when you take it, and the interest is high.

The seven triggers

Not every task makes you want to run. Some you do easily, even happily. So what is it about the ones you avoid?

Timothy Pychyl lists seven features that make a task more likely to be put off. The more of them a task has, the stronger the urge to delay. A task is more likely to be avoided when it is:

1. **Boring.** Filing expenses, formatting references, cleaning out the inbox.
2. **Frustrating.** Software that keeps crashing, a form that keeps rejecting your answers, a client who never replies.
3. **Difficult.** A topic you don't understand yet, a problem without an obvious answer.

4. **Ambiguous.** You're not sure what "done" looks like or what's expected.
5. **Unstructured.** No clear first step or order of steps.
6. **Lacking intrinsic reward.** There's nothing enjoyable in the doing of it.
7. **Lacking personal meaning.** You can't see why it matters to you.

Amira's proposal scored high on several. It was ambiguous (how much detail did the firm want?), unstructured (where do you even start a proposal?), difficult (she had never priced a job that size) and, most of all, it touched a sore spot. Writing it meant putting a number on her own worth and waiting to be judged.

That last one deserves its own section.

Fear in disguise

A lot of procrastination has little to do with the task itself. The real worry is what the task might say about you.

If you never start the essay, nobody can tell you it's bad. If you never send the application, you can't be rejected. If you never publish the video, you'll never read a cruel comment. As long as the work stays unfinished, it stays full of potential, and so do you.

This is why perfectionists often procrastinate more, not less. When the standard is "perfect", every attempt is a likely failure, so the safest move is not to attempt. Some people also delay as a kind of insurance. If the result is poor, they can blame the lack of time instead of their ability. "I only started it the night before" protects your self-image in a way that "I tried my best and it wasn't good enough" doesn't.

None of this is conscious, usually. Amira didn't think, "I am avoiding this proposal to protect my self-esteem." She just felt a heaviness whenever she opened the document and a lightness whenever she closed it. The avoidance did its work without her noticing.

The procrastination equation

Piers Steel also offered a way of thinking about why we delay that some people find useful. In simplified form, your motivation to do a task goes up when you expect to succeed at it and when you value the result. It goes down when the reward is far away and when you're easily distracted.

You don't need the maths. The four parts are enough, because each one points to something you can change:

- **Raise your expectation of success.** Break the task into steps small enough that you know you can do the first one.
- **Raise the value.** Connect the task to something you care about, or add something enjoyable to it.
- **Shorten the delay.** Create a reward or deadline that comes sooner, such as a small milestone for today, not just the big deadline in a month.
- **Lower your impulsiveness.** Remove the easy escapes before you start, so the temptation is not right there.

You'll find tools for each of these later in the book. For now, notice that "try harder" isn't on the list. Every lever is about changing the task or the setting, not about becoming a different person.

What helps

Once you see procrastination as a way of escaping a feeling, some useful things follow.

Name the feeling. When you notice yourself avoiding something, stop and ask: *What am I feeling about this task right now?* Bored? Anxious? Confused? Resentful? Just putting a word to it often takes some of the heat out. It also tells you which trigger you're dealing with, and that points to the fix. Ambiguity needs clarifying. Difficulty needs breaking down. Boredom needs a time limit or a reward.

Shrink the first step. Large, vague tasks are threatening. Small, clear ones aren't. "Write the proposal" is frightening. "Open the firm's email and list the three things they asked for" is not. Chapter 11 goes into this in detail, but the basic move is simple: make the first step so small it feels almost silly.

Agree to only ten minutes. Tell yourself you'll work on the task for ten minutes, and after that you're free to stop. Often you won't. Starting is the hardest part, and once you're moving, the bad feeling usually fades. But even if you do stop after ten minutes, you've made progress and you've shown yourself that the task is survivable.

Expect the discomfort. You don't have to feel good to start. You can feel reluctant, anxious and bored and still do the work. Waiting until the bad feeling goes away is a trap, because the feeling often only goes away once you've started. Pychyl's advice is blunt and useful: you don't need to feel like doing it. Just get started.

Forgive yourself for yesterday. It sounds soft. It isn't. In Chapter 15 you'll read about a study showing that students who forgave themselves for procrastinating before one exam procrastinated less before the next. Guilt and shame make tasks feel even worse, which makes you want to avoid them even more. Letting go of yesterday clears the way for today.

What Amira did

On the tenth day, Amira tried something a friend suggested. She didn't open the proposal document. Instead, she wrote one line in her notebook: *What am I actually afraid of here?*

The answer came quickly. She was afraid of quoting too high and losing the job, or quoting too low and looking like an amateur. Everything else, the structure, the wording, the layout, she knew how to do.

That changed the task. The problem wasn't "write a proposal". It was "find out what a fair price is". That was a research question, and research she could do. She spent forty minutes looking at what other designers charged, messaged two people she'd studied with, and wrote down a price range. Then she set a timer for twenty-five minutes and wrote the ugliest possible first draft of the proposal, with the number in it.

She sent it two days later. She got the job.

"The proposal took about four hours in total," she said. "The avoiding took nine days."

Try this today

Start a procrastination log. You'll use it again in the 30-day challenge.

For the next three days, every time you notice yourself putting something off, write down five things:

1. **The task** you're avoiding.
2. **What you did instead.**
3. **The feeling** the task gave you, in one or two words.
4. **Which of the seven triggers** it hits (boring, frustrating, difficult, ambiguous, unstructured, no reward, no meaning).
5. **A smaller first step** that would make it easier to begin.

Then pick one item from your log and do its smaller first step, for ten minutes, today.

Reflection

- Which task have I been putting off the longest, and what feeling sits underneath it?
- What do I usually do instead when I'm avoiding something? Does it feel productive?
- If a friend told me they'd been avoiding this task, what would I say to them?

Chapter 3: The feed is built to keep you

Sana did not think she had a problem with her phone. She had a problem with time, which seemed to vanish in the evenings, and with concentration, which seemed to have gotten worse since she started university. But the phone? Everyone used their phone.

Then her screen-time report arrived one Sunday morning. Her daily average for the past week was six hours and fifty-two minutes. Three hours and ten minutes of it was in a single short-video app. She had picked the phone up 143 times a day.

Her first reaction was that the number must be wrong. Her second was to do the arithmetic. If she was awake for about sixteen hours, she was picking up the phone roughly every seven minutes. She had never once, in that week, decided to spend three hours watching videos. She'd only ever decided to watch one.

You're not imagining it

If you find it hard to put your phone down, it's worth knowing that you're up against something designed by skilled people to be hard to put down. That's not a conspiracy theory. It's the business model.

Most social media apps and many video and news platforms make money from advertising. Advertisers pay for attention. The more

time you spend in the app, the more ads you see and the more the company earns. So these companies employ large teams of engineers, designers and data scientists whose job, measured in hard numbers, is to increase how long and how often you use the product. They test changes on millions of people and keep whatever works.

What works, it turns out, are some old and well-understood features of human psychology.

The slot machine in your pocket

In the middle of the twentieth century, the psychologist B. F. Skinner studied how animals learn from rewards. One of his findings was that rewards which arrive unpredictably, sometimes yes and sometimes no, produce more persistent behavior than rewards that arrive every time. A pigeon that gets food every time it pecks a key will peck when it's hungry. A pigeon that gets food on some pecks, at random, will peck and peck and peck.

Slot machines are built on this principle. So, whether or not anyone planned it that way, are feeds.

When you pull down to refresh, you don't know what you'll get. Maybe a message from someone you like. Maybe a funny video. Maybe nothing. When you scroll, the next post might be boring or it might be the best thing you've seen all week. That uncertainty is exactly what keeps your thumb moving. You're not scrolling for what you just saw. You're scrolling for what might come next.

No bottoms, no edges

Older media had natural stopping points. A newspaper ran out of pages. A television episode ended and you had to decide whether

to watch another. A magazine had a back cover.

Modern feeds removed those edges. Infinite scroll means there's always more below. Autoplay means the next video starts before you've decided whether you want it. Stories disappear after a day, which creates a small pressure to check before you miss them. Streaks reward you for opening an app every single day, and punish you, mildly, for missing one.

Aza Raskin, the designer usually credited with inventing infinite scroll, has spoken publicly about regretting how it's been used. He meant it as a convenience. It turned out to remove the one moment, at the bottom of the page, where people used to stop and ask themselves whether they wanted to continue.

Every time you finish something and have to choose to start the next thing, you get a small chance to stop. A lot of good design for focus, as you'll see in Chapter 6, is about putting those stopping points back.

The cost of a buzz

Notifications are a separate problem. They don't just tempt you when you're already on your phone. They reach out and pull you in while you're doing something else.

In a 2015 study at Florida State University, Cary Stothart and his colleagues gave people a task that required sustained attention. While they worked, some received phone calls or text notifications on their own phones. They didn't answer them or even look at them. The researchers found that just receiving the notifications was enough to significantly hurt performance on the task, to a degree comparable to actually using a phone.

It makes sense when you think about it. A buzz in your pocket doesn't just make a noise. It starts a chain of thoughts: *Who's that? Is it important? Should I check? I'll check later. But what if it's…?* Even if you never pick up the phone, part of your attention has left the work.

The checking habit

Notice how often you pick up your phone without any reason. Not to reply to something, not to look something up. You just find it in your hand, unlocked, with your thumb hovering over an app.

This is habit, and it's powerful because it's automatic. Somewhere along the way, your brain learned that small moments of boredom, discomfort or waiting can be relieved by the phone. Standing in a queue: phone. A pause in conversation: phone. A hard paragraph in your textbook: phone. The phone became the answer to every small gap in the day, and so now every gap triggers a reach.

Gloria Mark, whose interruption research you met in Chapter 1, has tracked how long people stay on one screen before switching. In her 2023 book *Attention Span*, she reports that in her more recent studies the average was around forty-seven seconds. Some of those switches are caused by notifications. Many of them aren't. People interrupt themselves, all day long, out of habit.

Many people also experience "phantom vibrations", the feeling that their phone has buzzed when it hasn't. It's a small, strange sign of how closely tuned we've become to our devices.

Comparison and the highlight reel

There's another cost that has less to do with time and more to do with how you feel.

Social media shows you a curated selection of other people's lives: the holidays, the promotions, the engagements, the perfect bodies, the beautifully lit desks of people who claim to wake at five and do everything right. You compare this highlight reel with your own ordinary, unfiltered day. You almost always lose.

For a student like Sana, that comparison often lands at exactly the wrong moment. She opens an app for a quick break from studying, sees a classmate posting about how much she's already revised, and comes back to her notes feeling anxious and behind. The break meant to refresh her has left her worse off.

What happens when people cut back

If social media is costly, what happens when people use less of it? A few well-designed studies give some useful answers.

In 2018, Melissa Hunt and her colleagues at the University of Pennsylvania asked a group of students to limit their use of Facebook, Instagram and Snapchat to ten minutes per platform per day, thirty minutes in total, for three weeks. A comparison group carried on as usual. The students who cut back reported significant reductions in loneliness and depression compared with the other group, and the effects were largest for those who had started out more depressed.

In a much larger study, published in 2020, the economists Hunt Allcott, Luca Braghieri, Sarah Eichmeyer and Matthew Gentzkow paid some participants to deactivate their Facebook accounts for four weeks. Those who deactivated freed up about an hour a day. They spent more time offline, including with friends and family, and reported small but real improvements in happiness and life satisfaction. When the experiment ended, many of them used

Facebook less than before, by their own choice. About eight in ten said the break had been good for them.

These findings don't say that social media is poison. The same Allcott study found that people valued Facebook a great deal; most of them had to be paid a meaningful sum to give it up. Social media lets you keep in touch with family abroad, find communities, learn things, run a business. Amira gets most of her customers through it.

What the studies do say is that, for many people, less is better than more, and that we tend to underestimate how much better our lives can feel with a little less.

Whose job is it?

Here's the balance this book tries to strike.

It's not a personal failing that your phone is hard to resist. You're a human being facing a product designed by experts to hold human attention, and it's doing what it was built to do.

But understanding that doesn't get you off the hook. Nobody is going to redesign these apps to protect your study time. The companies won't, and the government probably won't, at least not soon. If you want your attention back, you have to take it back yourself.

The good news is that you don't need superhuman willpower to do it. You need to work with the same psychology that's working against you. If unpredictable rewards make apps sticky, you can remove the apps from your home screen. If notifications break your attention, you can turn them off. If the phone is the answer to every boring moment, you can give boredom a different answer.

If the feed has no bottom, you can put a stopping point back with a timer or a time window.

Chapter 6 takes you through all of this, step by step. For now, the most important thing is to see clearly what's happening.

What Sana noticed

After the shock of her screen-time report, Sana didn't delete anything. She did something smaller. For three days, every time she picked up her phone, she said the reason under her breath: "reply to Mum", "check the bus", "bored", "avoiding the essay".

By the end of the first day she was embarrassed by how often the reason was "bored" or "no reason". By the end of the third, she'd started catching her hand on the way to the phone and putting it back down before she'd unlocked it.

"I didn't know I was doing it," she said. "That was the scary part. I thought I was choosing to use my phone. Most of the time, I wasn't choosing anything."

Try this today

Do a screen-time audit. It takes about fifteen minutes.

1. Open the screen-time or digital well-being section in your phone's settings. (On most iPhones it's under Settings, then Screen Time. On most Android phones it's under Settings, then Digital Wellbeing.)
2. Write down three numbers: your average daily screen time over the past week, the number of times you picked up or unlocked the phone each day, and the number of notifications you received each day.

3. List the top five apps by time.
4. For each of those five, write one honest sentence: *What does this app give me, and what does it cost me?*
5. Circle the app that costs you the most compared with what it gives you. You'll come back to it in Chapter 6.

Then, for the rest of today, try Sana's experiment. Each time you pick up your phone, say (or think) the reason before you unlock it.

Reflection

- When I look at my numbers, what surprises me most?
- In which situations do I reach for my phone most often: boredom, waiting, avoiding work, loneliness, habit?
- If I got back one hour a day, what would I want to use it for?

Chapter 4: The daydream and the loop

Tariq had been learning to code for seven months. Most evenings after dinner he sat at the kitchen table with his laptop and an online course, and most evenings, about ten minutes in, something happened that he found hard to describe.

He would be reading an explanation of how a loop works, and somewhere in the middle of a sentence he would be gone. In his mind he was already a software developer. He was walking into a bright office, introducing himself to his new team, explaining to his old manager at the accountancy firm that he was leaving. He was telling his teenage son about the app he'd built. The scene was vivid and pleasant and detailed. It felt almost real.

Then he'd blink, and the page in front of him would still be on the same paragraph about loops, and twenty minutes would have passed.

"It's like I'm watching a film of my life," he said, "instead of living it. Sometimes I think I've seen that film more often than I've written code."

When your mind leaves the room

Some people call this "hallucinating" about the future, or about their goals. It's a vivid way to put it, and you'll probably recognize

the experience: the scenes that play out while you stare at a page, so real that you forget where you are.

Strictly speaking, though, it isn't hallucination. A hallucination, in the medical sense, means seeing, hearing or feeling something that isn't there, as if it were actually happening in the world, such as hearing voices or seeing figures that others can't. That's a health matter, not a productivity one, and if it happens to you, the right step is to talk to a doctor. Nothing in this chapter is a substitute for that.

What Tariq experiences is something almost everyone does every day. Psychologists call it mind-wandering: the attention drifting away from the task in front of you to thoughts, images and stories of its own. Sometimes it's a pleasant daydream. Sometimes it's a worry that loops round and round. Sometimes it's just a blank, where you've been reading without taking anything in.

How much of the time we're elsewhere

In 2010, two Harvard psychologists, Matthew Killingsworth and Daniel Gilbert, published a study that used an iPhone app to check in on people at random moments during their day. The app asked what they were doing, whether they were thinking about something other than what they were doing, and how happy they felt.

The results were striking. Across about 2,250 adults, people's minds were wandering in 46.9 percent of the samples. Nearly half of waking life, in other words, was spent thinking about something other than what was happening. And people were generally less happy when their minds were wandering than when they weren't, even when the daydreams were about pleasant things.

The title of the paper summed it up: “A wandering mind is an unhappy mind.”

That doesn’t mean you should try to stop your mind from ever wandering. You can’t, and you wouldn’t want to. It does mean that if you sometimes look up from a page and realize you’ve been somewhere else, you’re not broken. You’re a normal human being, and the skill you need is not to stop wandering but to notice it sooner and come back.

When daydreaming helps

Not all mind-wandering is a problem. A wandering mind is also how you plan, imagine, solve problems and connect ideas. Many people have their best ideas in the shower, on a walk or while washing dishes, precisely because their mind is free to drift.

In 2012, a team led by Benjamin Baird gave people a creative problem, then a break. During the break, some did a demanding task, some rested, and some did an easy task that left plenty of room for the mind to wander. When they came back to the original problem, the easy-task group improved the most. Letting the mind roam, it seems, helped ideas incubate.

So there’s a time for daydreaming. The trouble is when it shows up at the wrong time, in the middle of work that needs your full attention, and when it replaces the action instead of fueling it.

The trap of the beautiful fantasy

Tariq’s daydreams were about his goal. He wasn’t escaping into something unrelated; he was imagining success. Surely that’s motivating?

Not necessarily. The psychologist Gabriele Oettingen has spent decades studying what happens when people fantasize about their goals. In one early study, published in 1991, she followed women on a weight-loss program. Those who had the most positive fantasies about how slim and confident they'd become lost less weight than those whose thoughts about the future were more mixed or realistic. Later studies found similar patterns with students, job seekers and people recovering from surgery.

Her explanation is that a vivid positive fantasy can give your mind a taste of success before you've earned it. You feel a little of the satisfaction already, and that takes away some of the drive to do the work. The dream becomes a reward in itself.

Oettingen's answer, which you'll use in Chapter 14, isn't to stop dreaming. It's to follow the dream with a hard look at what stands in the way. Dream, then picture the obstacle, then make a plan. That combination turns out to be much more powerful than either positive thinking or plain realism alone.

The worry loop

The other kind of mind-wandering is less pleasant. You're trying to work, and your mind keeps returning to a worry. The argument you had yesterday. The bill you haven't paid. Whether your manager was annoyed in this morning's meeting. What you'll do if you fail the exam.

Psychologists call repetitive negative thinking like this rumination when it's about the past and worry when it's about the future. Both feel like problem-solving, which is why they're hard to stop. Your mind seems to be working on something important. But real problem-solving moves forward: you understand more, you decide

something, you take a step. A loop goes round and round and lands back where it started.

Overthinking also shows up as analysis paralysis. You can't start the assignment until you've chosen the perfect topic. You can't launch the shop until you've compared every website platform. You can't send the message until you've rewritten it eleven times. Each option opens more questions, and the action you need to take gets buried under the thinking about it.

Perfectionism: the high bar that keeps you on the ground

Perfectionism and overthinking often travel together. If you believe your work must be flawless, every decision becomes high-stakes, and every draft is a potential embarrassment.

Healthy high standards are a good thing. They push you to do work you're proud of. The problem comes when the standard is so high that nothing can meet it, and when your sense of your own worth rides on meeting it. Then starting becomes frightening, finishing becomes impossible (there's always one more thing to fix), and sharing your work feels like exposing yourself to judgment.

The psychologist Barry Schwartz and his colleagues described a related pattern in decision-making. Some people are "maximizers": they want the best possible option and keep searching until they're sure they've found it. Others are "satisficers": they set a standard of good enough and take the first option that meets it. In their studies, maximizers often ended up with slightly better outcomes on paper but felt worse about their choices, with more regret and less satisfaction.

For most everyday tasks, good enough is the right target. Save the maximizing for the few decisions that truly deserve it.

Bringing your mind back

Here are five ways to work with a wandering mind, from the simplest to the more involved.

1. Notice and name it. When you realize your mind has wandered, silently name where it went: "planning", "worrying", "daydreaming", "remembering". Then return to the task. Don't scold yourself. The moment of noticing is the skill you're building, and every return is a small repetition, like a lift at the gym. Over time, you'll start noticing sooner.

2. Use a parking page. Keep a sheet of paper beside you while you work. When a thought pops up that seems important ("call the bank", "idea for the website"), write it down in a few words and return to work. Your mind often keeps nagging because it's afraid you'll forget. Writing the thought down tells it you won't.

There's research behind this. In 2011, E. J. Masicampo and Roy Baumeister found that unfinished goals tend to intrude on people's thoughts while they're trying to do something else. But when people made a specific plan for the unfinished goal, the intrusions largely stopped, even though the goal still wasn't done. A plan, it seems, is enough to let the mind put something down.

3. Schedule your worry. If the same worries keep returning, give them a time slot. Choose fifteen or twenty minutes each day, not too close to bedtime, as your "worry time". When a worry appears outside that slot, write it down and tell yourself you'll deal with it then. When worry time comes, sit down with the list and think properly: what can you actually do about each item? Many people find that by the time worry time arrives, half the worries don't seem so urgent. Researchers have tested this "worry postpone-

ment" approach since the 1980s, with encouraging results for many people.

4. Give the dream a job. If, like Tariq, you daydream about your goals, don't fight it. Schedule it. Spend five minutes before you start work picturing where you want to go, then picture the main obstacle, then write down your next small step. After that, the dream has done its job, and when it shows up again in the middle of work you can tell it, gently, "Not now. We've already done this today."

5. Set a "good enough" standard before you start. For any task you tend to overthink, decide in advance what good enough looks like and how much time you'll give it. "This email needs to be clear and polite, and I'll spend ten minutes on it." "I'll compare three website platforms, not twenty, and choose by Friday." When you hit the standard or the time limit, you stop.

When it's more than ordinary

Everyone's mind wanders, and everyone worries. But some people find it much harder than others to keep their attention on a task, and some carry worries that are so heavy and constant that they get in the way of daily life.

If you have always found concentration much harder than the people around you, or if your mind races so much that you can't work, sleep or relax, it's worth speaking to a doctor. Conditions such as ADHD, anxiety disorders and depression can all affect attention, and they're treatable. The techniques in this book can still help alongside proper support, but they're not a replacement for it. And, as mentioned at the start of this chapter, if you ever see or hear things that other people don't, please get medical advice.

What Tariq changed

Tariq's fix was surprisingly small. Before he opened the course each evening, he spent three minutes on what he called his "film". He let himself picture the new job as vividly as he liked. Then he wrote one sentence about what might stop him that evening ("I'm tired and I'll want to watch the match") and one sentence about what he'd do about it ("Code for twenty-five minutes first, then watch the second half").

When he caught himself drifting during the lesson, he made a small tick on his parking page and went back to the code. The first night he made fourteen ticks. Two weeks later it was usually four or five.

"I still daydream," he said. "I'm not going to stop. But now I watch the film once, at the start, and then I go and do the work that makes it true."

Try this today

Do a twenty-minute mind-wandering check.

1. Choose a task that needs concentration, and set a timer for twenty minutes.
2. Keep a sheet of paper beside you, divided into two columns: "Wandered" and "Parked".
3. Each time you notice your mind has wandered, put a tick in the first column and silently name where it went (worrying, planning, daydreaming, remembering). Then go back to the task.
4. Each time a useful thought or to-do appears, write it in a few words in the second column and go back to the task.

5. At the end, count the ticks. Don't judge the number. It's a starting point, and you can check again in a couple of weeks to see whether it has changed.

If you're a regular worrier, also choose a fifteen-minute worry time for tomorrow and write it in your calendar.

Reflection

- When my mind wanders, where does it most often go?
- Is there a daydream I return to so often that it has started to replace the work?
- Which task do I overthink, and what would "good enough" look like for it?

Part Two: Take back your attention

Attention can be trained, protected and given a better place to work. These four chapters show you how.

Chapter 5: Train your focus

When Sana decided to fix her studying, she did what most people do. She planned a heroic Saturday: eight hours in the library, phone switched off, no breaks except lunch. She lasted fifty minutes. After that she was so restless she went for a coffee, checked her phone "just for the time" and didn't come back to the library at all.

She came home convinced she had no attention span left. "Maybe my brain is just broken," she told her sister.

Her brain wasn't broken. She had tried to run a marathon without ever having jogged around the block.

Attention is a skill

It's tempting to think of focus as something you either have or don't, like eye color. In fact, it behaves much more like a skill or a level of fitness. It responds to practice. It weakens without use. It's better on some days than others, depending on sleep, stress and what you've been doing. And like fitness, it improves fastest when you start where you are, not where you wish you were.

If you've spent the past few years switching tasks every few minutes and filling every gap with your phone, your attention has had a lot of practice at switching and very little at staying. That's not a moral failing. It's training, just training in the wrong direction. The good news is that the same process works the other way.

Start where you actually are

The first step is honest measurement. How long can you currently work on something demanding before your attention breaks?

For many people the answer is somewhere between ten and twenty minutes. For some it's less. That's fine. If your real number is twelve minutes, then a session of fifteen is a stretch and a session of ninety is a fantasy. Start at fifteen.

The aim in the early weeks isn't to work for long periods. It's to build a track record of sessions where you set out to focus for a certain time and actually did. Every successful session teaches your brain that this is something you do. Every failed heroic attempt teaches it the opposite.

The focus ladder

Here's a simple progression you can follow over four to six weeks. Move up a rung only when the current one feels comfortable on most days.

1. **Rung one: 10 to 15 minutes** of focused work, then a 5-minute break. One or two sessions a day.
2. **Rung two: 20 to 25 minutes**, then a 5-minute break. Two or three sessions a day.
3. **Rung three: 35 to 45 minutes**, then a 10-minute break. Two or three sessions a day.
4. **Rung four: 50 to 60 minutes**, then a 10-to-15-minute break. Two or three sessions a day.
5. **Rung five: 75 to 90 minutes**, then a longer break of 20 minutes or so. One or two of these a day is plenty for most people.

Most people never need to go beyond rung four or five. Ninety minutes of truly focused work is a lot. Two or three of those blocks a day, done regularly, will put you ahead of almost everyone who sits at a desk for ten hours with their phone buzzing.

If you have a bad day, drop down a rung. That's not failure. Athletes vary their training load every day.

What counts as a focus session

A focus session has four features. Without them, it's just time spent near your work.

One clear target. Before you start, write down what you want to finish or reach by the end of the session. "Read pages 40 to 55 and write a five-line summary." "Draft the introduction." "Fix the bug in the login form." As you learned in Chapter 1, a clear finish line is what your attention steers by.

One task. Only the target task, and whatever is directly needed for it. If you need a reference, you can look it up. If you suddenly want to check the weather, you can't.

A boundary. A timer, so you know when the session ends. This matters more than it seems. Knowing there's a break coming in twenty minutes makes it much easier to resist the urge to take one now.

Protection. Phone out of reach, notifications off, unnecessary tabs closed, a door closed if you have one. You'll learn more ways to do this in the next two chapters.

What to do when your mind drifts

It will drift. That's guaranteed, especially in the first few weeks. The question isn't whether your attention leaves, but what you do when you notice.

Use the method from Chapter 4. Notice, name it in a word, and return. If a useful thought appears, write it on your parking page and return. If a strong urge appears, to check your phone or open a new tab, try what some therapists call "urge surfing". Notice the urge as a physical sensation: a restlessness in your hands, a tightness in your chest, a sort of itch. Don't act on it and don't fight it. Just watch it for a minute or two, the way you'd watch a wave rise and fall. Urges usually peak and fade within a few minutes if you don't feed them.

Nir Eyal, who writes about distraction, suggests a related rule he calls the ten-minute rule: when you feel the urge to give in to a distraction, tell yourself you can, but only after ten minutes. Often, by then, the urge has passed. If it hasn't, at least you've practiced waiting.

Every time you bring your attention back, you've done one repetition of the most important exercise in this book. Some sessions will have dozens of repetitions. That's not a bad session. That's a workout.

Tolerating boredom

One reason focus is hard now is that we've almost forgotten how to be bored. Every queue, every bus ride, every lull in a lecture can be filled instantly with something more interesting. So when a task gets dull, or difficult, or slow, our minds are out of practice at staying with it.

Deep focus almost always includes some boredom and some discomfort. Learning a new topic means sitting with confusion for a while. Writing means facing a blank page. Solving a problem means not knowing the answer, sometimes for a long time.

You can practice tolerating this outside of work. Try these, a few times a week:

- Wait in a queue without your phone.
- Take a short walk without headphones.
- Eat one meal a day without a screen.
- Sit for five minutes doing nothing at all, and notice what happens in your mind.

These sound trivial. They're not. Each one teaches your brain that a moment without stimulation is survivable, and that makes it easier to stay with a slow task when it matters.

A simple attention exercise

If you'd like a direct way to train attention, try this short daily practice. It's a basic form of breath-focused meditation, and you don't need any special beliefs or equipment.

1. Sit comfortably. Set a timer for five minutes.
2. Close your eyes or let your gaze rest on a spot in front of you.
3. Pay attention to the feeling of your breath, at the nose, chest or belly, wherever it's easiest to notice.
4. When your mind wanders, which it will within seconds, notice where it went, and gently bring it back to the breath.
5. Repeat until the timer ends.

That's it. The goal isn't to empty your mind or to feel calm, although you may. The goal is to practice noticing and returning, over and over, in a setting with no pressure. It's the same skill you need at your desk, practiced in the simplest possible conditions. Many people find five minutes a day makes a noticeable difference within a few weeks. If you enjoy it, you can extend it to ten or fifteen.

The role of interest

It's much easier to focus on something you find interesting. That's obvious, but it has a useful consequence: you can often make a task easier to focus on by making it more interesting.

Ask a question before you read. Instead of "read Chapter 6", try "find out why this drug interacts with grapefruit juice". A question gives your attention something to hunt for. Turn a task into a challenge: can you finish the first draft in forty minutes? Explain what you're learning out loud, as if to a friend. Connect it to something you care about: how will this skill help you in the job you want?

None of this turns every task into fun. But a task with a question, a challenge or a reason attached is far easier to stay with than one you're simply getting through.

Tracking your progress

Keep a simple focus log. After each session, write down the date, how long it was, what the target was, whether you reached it, and roughly how many times your attention wandered. Once a week, look back.

After a few weeks, you'll see things you couldn't see before. Maybe your best sessions are in the morning. Maybe they're worse after

you've been on social media. Maybe you're more focused in the library than at home. Maybe your wandering count is slowly dropping. The log turns vague impressions ("I'm terrible at concentrating") into evidence you can act on.

What happened to Sana

Sana started again, this time at rung one. Fifteen minutes, then a break. She did two sessions on the first day and felt almost silly at how short they were.

But she finished both. The next day she did three. After a week she moved to twenty-five minutes, and after three weeks to forty. By the end of the month she could reliably do two forty-five-minute sessions in the evening, with a proper break in between, and she was getting through more pharmacology in those ninety minutes than she used to in a whole distracted evening.

"The first week felt like I was doing nothing," she said. "It was only when I looked at my log that I saw I'd done more focused studying that week than the whole month before."

Try this today

Find your starting rung.

1. Choose a task that needs concentration and write down a clear target for it.
2. Put your phone in another room and close everything you don't need.
3. Start a stopwatch (counting up, not down) and work until you notice your focus has truly broken: you've drifted several times in a row, or you find yourself reaching for something else.

4. Stop the stopwatch and write down the time.
5. Your starting session length is about that number, rounded down to the nearest five minutes. If it was 18 minutes, start at 15.
6. Write down tomorrow's plan: how many sessions, how long each, and when.

Then, if you can, do one five-minute breathing practice before bed.

Reflection

- What is my honest starting session length today?
- Which rung of the focus ladder do I want to reach in six weeks?
- Where in my day could I practice a few minutes of being bored on purpose?

Chapter 6: The digital reset

Most advice about phones falls into one of two camps. One says throw it in a lake: delete everything, buy a basic phone, live like it's 1995. The other says it's fine, just use it mindfully, as if a little more mindfulness could outmatch a billion-dollar engineering team.

Neither works for most people. You probably can't give up your smartphone. You need it for work, for family, for banking, for maps, for the bus timetable. And "be mindful" is advice you've almost certainly already tried.

This chapter takes a middle road. You'll keep your phone and the parts of it that genuinely help you. You'll change its settings, its layout and its place in your day so that it stops ambushing you. The goal is to make the phone a tool you pick up on purpose, not a slot machine that picks you up.

You don't have to do every step at once. Read through, then choose three to start with.

Step 1: Clear out the notifications

Notifications are the phone's way of interrupting you. Most of them don't deserve to.

Go into your notification settings and look at every app. For each one, ask a single question: *Does a human being need me, right now,*

through this app?

- A message from your partner, your child, your manager or a close friend: probably yes.
- A phone call: yes.
- A calendar reminder you set yourself: yes.
- Someone liked your photo: no.
- A news alert: no. The news will still be there in an hour.
- A shopping app telling you about a sale: no.
- A game telling you your energy has refilled: definitely no.
- Email: for most people, no. You'll check email on purpose, at set times (Chapter 8 explains how).

Turn off everything that fails the test. For many people that's most of their apps. If you're nervous, turn them off for one week and see whether you miss anything important. You almost certainly won't, and you'll notice how much quieter your days become.

For the notifications you keep, consider turning off the sound and vibration for all but calls and messages from your most important people. Most phones let you mark certain contacts as favorites or emergency contacts who can always get through.

Step 2: Use focus modes

Modern phones have focus modes, sometimes called do-not-disturb, work mode, study mode or bedtime mode. These let you silence almost everything during certain hours, while still letting chosen people or apps through.

Set up at least two:

- **A work or study mode**, for your focus sessions. Only calls and messages from a short list of people get through.
- **A sleep mode**, starting thirty to sixty minutes before you want to be asleep and ending when you get up.

Schedule them to turn on automatically. Deciding each time is just another chance to decide not to.

Step 3: Redesign your home screen

The first screen you see when you unlock your phone works like a shop window. Whatever's there gets tapped, often before you've decided to tap it.

Move every app that tends to swallow your time off the home screen. Social media, video, news, games, shopping: put them in a folder on the second or third page, or remove them from the home screen entirely and open them by searching. Leave only tools on the first screen: phone, messages, calendar, maps, camera, notes, perhaps a music app.

This tiny bit of friction works because so much phone use is automatic. If opening an app requires swiping twice and typing its name, you'll often notice what you're doing in time to stop.

Step 4: Delete the worst app from your phone

Remember the app you circled in Chapter 3, the one that costs you the most for what it gives? Delete it from your phone.

You don't have to delete your account. Most social media works on a computer browser too. Use it there, on purpose, when you choose to sit down for it. You'll find that using a platform on a laptop,

without the endless thumb-scroll, is a very different and much less sticky experience.

If you can't delete it, perhaps because you use it for work as Amira does, log out after each use. Having to type your password back in is another small speed bump.

Step 5: Try grayscale

This one sounds strange, but it's worth a try. Most phones have an accessibility setting that turns the screen black and white. Search your settings for "grayscale", "color filters" or "monochrome".

Apps use bright colors, red badges and vivid images partly because color grabs attention. Remove the color, and the whole phone becomes noticeably less appealing. In a study published by Alex Holte and Richard Ferraro at the University of North Dakota, college students who switched their phones to grayscale reduced their daily screen time significantly compared with how they'd used their phones before.

You'll still be able to do everything you need. You'll just be less drawn to do things you don't. Many phones let you set up a shortcut, such as triple-clicking a button, to switch color back on briefly when you need it, for example to look at a photo.

Step 6: Give your phone a home

Where your phone sits matters. If it's in your hand or on your desk, you'll check it. If it's in another room, you mostly won't, simply because getting up is effort.

You may have read that the mere presence of a phone on your desk, even switched off, drains your brainpower. That idea comes from a 2017 study by Adrian Ward and colleagues, which got a lot

of attention. Later attempts to repeat the experiment have not found the same effect, so it's best treated as uncertain. But you don't need that study to make the case. A phone within reach is a phone you can pick up in half a second without thinking. A phone in another room takes a decision and a walk.

So give your phone a home that isn't your desk and isn't your bed. A shelf in the hallway. A basket in the kitchen. A drawer. During focus sessions, that's where it lives.

Step 7: Take the phone out of the bedroom

If you can make only one big change, make it this one.

Phones in the bedroom cause two problems. At night, they keep you up: one more video, one more scroll, and then the light and the stimulation make it harder to fall asleep. In the morning, they grab you before you've even sat up. Many people start their day by checking messages, email and news in bed, which means their first thoughts of the day are reactions to other people's demands.

Buy a cheap alarm clock. Charge the phone outside the bedroom. For the first few nights it will feel strange. After a week or two most people say it's one of the best changes they've made.

If you truly need the phone nearby at night, for example because you're a carer or on call, put it across the room, face down, in sleep mode with only emergency contacts allowed through.

Step 8: Create checking windows

A lot of compulsive checking comes from uncertainty. *Has anyone replied? Did something happen?* If you check whenever you wonder, you'll check all day.

Instead, decide in advance when you'll check social media and messages that aren't urgent. For example: once at lunch, once at 5 p.m., once after dinner, fifteen minutes each. Outside those windows, you don't open those apps.

This works because it replaces a hundred small decisions with one big one. When the urge to check appears at 10:30 in the morning, you don't have to argue with yourself. You already decided: not until lunch.

Step 9: Use limits and blockers, carefully

Most phones let you set daily time limits for particular apps. When you reach the limit, the app is blocked or you get a warning. There are also apps and browser extensions that block certain sites during set hours.

These can help, especially at the start. The evidence on them is mixed, though. Many people find ways around their own blocks, such as tapping "ignore limit for today" or switching to the browser version. They work best as a reminder and a speed bump, not as a cage. If you find yourself overriding a limit every day, treat that as information: the underlying habit needs a different fix, usually a replacement (see Step 10).

For really stubborn cases, some blockers let you lock settings so they can't be changed for a set period. Use these for your hardest hours, such as exam season or a deadline week.

Step 10: Replace, don't only remove

Here's the step people most often skip, and it's the one that makes the others stick.

Your phone habit is meeting a need. Boredom, loneliness, stress, tiredness, the wish for a short break. If you take the phone away without meeting the need some other way, the need will win and you'll be back on the phone within days.

So for each situation where you usually reach for your phone, decide what you'll do instead:

- Waiting in a queue or on the bus: a book, a podcast you chose in advance, or just looking around.
- A short break from work: stand up, stretch, refill your water, look out of a window (Chapter 12 has more ideas).
- Feeling lonely: call or message one specific person, instead of scrolling past hundreds.
- Winding down at night: a paper book, a shower, light stretching, talking with someone you live with.
- Stressed or anxious: a walk, a few slow breaths, writing down what's worrying you.

Write your replacements down. Put the book on your bedside table and the alarm clock where the phone used to be. Make the new choice easier than the old one.

Short-form video: a special case

Short videos deserve a separate word, because many people find them harder to control than anything else on their phone. Each clip is seconds long, so there's no natural stopping point. The algorithm learns very quickly exactly what holds your attention, and the next clip is always ready.

If short videos are your main problem, the steps above still apply, but you may need to be firmer. Many people find "just a few" im-

possible and “none on the phone” much easier. Some delete the app and allow themselves to watch on a computer only, at set times. Others keep the app but disable autoplay, turn off notifications and set a hard daily limit. Experiment. But be honest with yourself about which approach actually works for you.

Social media with a purpose

If you want to keep using social media, and many people have good reasons to, try deciding what each platform is for.

Amira did this with a notebook page. She wrote: “Instagram is for posting my work and replying to customers. Not for scrolling other designers’ feeds.” With that rule, she set her checking windows to twice a day, unfollowed accounts that made her feel inadequate, and used the platform on her laptop for posting.

“I still get sucked in sometimes,” she said. “But I notice now, because I know what I’m meant to be doing there. Before, I didn’t have a reason. I just went.”

Cal Newport, in his book *Digital Minimalism*, suggests a stricter version: take a thirty-day break from optional technologies, then add back only the ones that clearly serve something you value, with clear rules for how you’ll use them. If your phone use feels badly out of control, that kind of complete reset can be easier than gradual cutting back.

When you slip

You will slip. One evening you’ll find yourself an hour deep in videos, with no memory of choosing it. That doesn’t mean the reset failed.

When it happens, skip the guilt and get curious. What was happening just before you picked up the phone? Were you tired, bored, avoiding something, lonely? Which of your new barriers did you go around, and how? What would make that barrier stronger, or what replacement would meet the need better?

Then reset. Put the phone back in its home, and carry on. A slip is a data point, not a verdict.

Try this today

Do a twenty-minute digital reset.

1. Go through your notification settings and turn off every notification that fails the test "Does a human being need me, right now, through this app?"
2. Set up a work or study focus mode and a sleep mode, scheduled to turn on automatically.
3. Move every time-swallowing app off your home screen.
4. Choose a home for your phone during focus sessions that isn't your desk.
5. Pick three replacements for the times you usually reach for your phone, and write them down.

Tonight, if you can, charge your phone outside your bedroom.

Reflection

- Which of these steps will be hardest for me, and why?
- What need is my phone habit meeting, and what else could meet it?
- How will I know, a month from now, that my relationship with my phone has improved?

Chapter 7: Build a room that helps you work

Daniel's desk was a small table wedged between the bed and the wardrobe. Behind him, in the camera view for every video call, was the laundry basket. To his left was the window onto the street. To his right, close enough to touch, was the bed. On the desk itself sat two coffee cups, a phone charger, his son's toy dinosaur, a pile of unopened post, a notebook, a second notebook, three pens that didn't work and a laptop with twenty-three browser tabs open.

He had never thought about the desk. It was just where the laptop was. But when he started paying attention to how his days went wrong, he noticed that the room kept handing him reasons to stop. The post reminded him of bills. The bed invited him to lie down "for five minutes" after lunch. The street outside was interesting in a way a spreadsheet never was. And because the room was also where he slept, it never fully felt like a place for work.

"I'd been trying to concentrate in a room that was designed for everything except concentrating," he said.

Your surroundings make decisions for you

We like to think our behavior comes from our choices. A lot of it actually comes from our surroundings.

Psychologists who study habits, such as Wendy Wood at the University of Southern California, have found that a large share of everyday behavior is cued by context: the place we're in, the time of day, the objects around us, the people nearby. You reach for snacks because they're on the counter. You check your phone because it's next to your hand. You work well in the library partly because everyone else is working, and you struggle at the kitchen table partly because it's also where you eat, talk and relax.

This is good news. It means you don't have to rely only on willpower. You can change the setting, and let the setting do some of the work.

The principle of friction

The simplest way to use your environment is to change how easy things are.

Every action has a little friction: the effort, time or thought it takes to start. A tiny change in friction can make a surprisingly large difference to how often you do something, because so many of our choices are made in a fraction of a second, on autopilot.

So the rule is:

- **Add friction to what distracts you.** Make it a bit harder, slower or more awkward to do.
- **Remove friction from what you want to do.** Make it a bit easier, faster and more obvious.

Phone in another room: friction added. Notes already open on the desk when you sit down: friction removed. Television remote in a drawer: friction added. Running shoes by the door: friction removed. Each change is small. Together they tilt the day.

One place, one purpose, if you can

If at all possible, keep a place for focused work that you use for nothing else. When you sit there, your brain learns to expect work, the same way it learns to expect sleep when you lie in bed.

It doesn't need to be a whole room. It can be a particular chair, one end of a table, a corner of the library, a specific café. What matters is that it's consistent, and that you don't use it for scrolling, gaming or watching films. If you do those things in the same chair, the chair learns to expect them too.

If you have to use one space for several purposes, which is true for millions of people, you can create the change with a ritual instead. Clear the table. Put out your work things. Switch on a particular lamp. Put on the same headphones. When you're finished, pack everything away. The space changes character because you've changed it on purpose.

Set up the desk

Look at your workspace and ask, for every object on it: *Does this help me with the work I'm doing now?*

If it doesn't, move it. Not into a drawer by the desk where you'll see it every time you open the drawer; somewhere else.

A good focus desk has:

- What you need for the current task, and nothing more.
- Your parking page and a pen, for capturing wandering thoughts (Chapter 4).
- Water.
- Good light. Daylight is best if you can get it, and a lamp that lights the work, not your eyes.

- A comfortable chair at a height that doesn't hurt your back or neck.

A good focus desk doesn't have your phone, unopened post, food you're trying not to eat, or anything that reminds you of a different task.

Daniel cleared his desk down to the laptop, one notebook and one working pen. He moved the post to a tray in the kitchen, where he went through it every Friday. He turned the desk ninety degrees so he faced a wall instead of the street, and bought a cheap folding screen to hide the bed from both himself and his video calls. The change took an hour and cost less than a meal out. He felt the difference the next morning.

Sound

People differ a lot in how they handle noise. Some can work in a busy café. Others need silence. Find out which you are by trying both.

If noise bothers you, the options are:

- **Earplugs**, simple and cheap.
- **Noise-cancelling headphones**, more expensive but very effective, especially in open offices and on public transport.
- **Steady background sound**, such as white noise, rain sounds or the general hum of a café. Many people find a constant, meaningless sound easier to ignore than occasional voices.
- **Music**, with care. Research on music while working is mixed. Familiar music without lyrics seems to bother most people less than music with words, especially for reading and writing, because words compete with the words you're trying to process. If

you work with music, try a few sessions without it and compare.

Headphones have another use too. In a shared space, they're a signal to other people that you're busy.

Working in a shared space

Tariq didn't have a study. He coded at the kitchen table, in a house with two teenagers, a wife who worked shifts, and a television in the next room. His focus sessions kept being broken by perfectly reasonable questions: "Dad, where's my charger?" "What are we having for dinner?" "Can you sign this form?"

What helped him was an agreement, not a lock. He sat down with his family and explained what he was doing and why it mattered to him. Then he asked for two things. First, between 8:00 and 9:00 on weeknights, unless something was urgent, could they save their questions until 9:00? Second, if he was wearing his headphones, could they assume he was working?

They agreed, and mostly they kept to it. When they forgot, he'd point at the headphones, smile, and hold up the number of minutes left. He also made sure 9:00 was a real time when he became fully available, which made it easier for everyone to wait.

If you live with other people, a few things make this kind of agreement work:

- **Explain the why.** People are more willing to help when they understand what it's for.
- **Be specific about times.** "I need some quiet sometimes" is easy to ignore. "Between eight and nine" is clear.

- **Use a signal.** Headphones, a closed door, a sign, a particular lamp that's on when you're working.
- **Define urgent.** Agree on what counts as a real interruption: injury, emergency, something that truly can't wait.
- **Keep your side of the deal.** When the focus time ends, be present.

For parents with young children, quiet focus at home may only be possible during naps, early mornings, late evenings, or when another adult is in charge. That's not a failure of planning; it's a season of life. Chapter 19 has more on this.

When home doesn't work

Sometimes, no matter what you do, home is too full of distractions or too full of people. Then it's worth finding another place.

Libraries are free in most places and full of people working, which helps. Some universities let the public use their libraries. Cafés work for some people, especially for tasks that don't need deep concentration. Some towns have co-working spaces that rent desks by the day. Even a parked car or a quiet corner of a park can work for reading or planning.

The very act of going somewhere to work can help. It creates a clear start (you arrive), a clear end (you leave), and it removes everything at home that might pull you away.

Your digital environment

Your computer is also an environment, and for most of us it's a cluttered one. Dozens of open tabs, a desktop covered in files,

email and chat running all day, notifications sliding in from the corner of the screen.

Apply the same principles:

- **Close what you don't need.** Before a focus session, close every tab and app you're not using for this task. If you're worried about losing them, bookmark them all in a folder called "Later".
- **Use full screen.** Most programs can be made to fill the screen, hiding everything else.
- **Turn off desktop notifications.** Email, chat and calendar notifications are as disruptive on a computer as on a phone. Turn them off during focus sessions, or completely.
- **Separate work and play.** Some people create a separate user account or browser profile for work, with no social media logged in, no entertainment bookmarks and a plain background. Logging in becomes a little ritual that says, "Now I'm working."
- **Tidy the desktop.** A clear desktop is calmer to look at. Put files in folders. It takes ten minutes.

Daniel had been keeping twenty-three tabs open out of a vague fear of forgetting something. When he finally closed them, he bookmarked the few that mattered and found he didn't miss the rest. "Most of them I'd opened weeks before and never looked at again," he said. "They were just sitting there, still asking for attention."

Make the good choice visible

Friction can work in the other direction too. Put cues for the things you want to do where you'll see them.

If you want to read more, leave a book on your pillow or the sofa. If you want to practice an instrument, leave it out of its case on a stand. If you want to study first thing, leave your notes open on the desk the night before, at the page where you'll start. If you want to drink more water, keep a full bottle on your desk.

James Clear, in his book *Atomic Habits*, puts it simply: make it obvious. A visible cue for a good habit is a small invitation every time you walk past.

Try this today

Redesign your workspace in thirty minutes.

1. Clear your desk or work area completely. Take everything off.
2. Put back only what you need for focused work: your current task, a parking page, a pen, water.
3. Find a new home for everything else, somewhere you won't see it while you work.
4. Check your light, your chair and your view. If you can, turn your desk so you face away from movement, windows onto busy streets or the television.
5. On your computer, close all unneeded tabs (bookmark them if you must) and turn off desktop notifications.
6. If you share your space, write down the agreement you'd like to suggest to the people you live with: what times, what signal, what counts as urgent.

Then leave tomorrow's first task open and ready, so it's the first thing you see when you sit down.

Reflection

- What in my current workspace most often pulls me away from work?
- Where do I do my best work, and what's different about that place?
- What one cue could I add to make a good habit more obvious?

Chapter 8: Deep work and single-tasking

Amira's best design work had always happened in a strange place: on the night bus home from her parents' house, two hours each way, once a month. No Wi-Fi. A sketchbook on her knee. Nothing to do but think.

For a long time she assumed it was the bus itself, some magic in the motion and the dark windows. Then one weekend she tried an experiment. She turned off the router at home, put her phone in a drawer, and sat at her kitchen table with the same sketchbook for two hours. She came up with three logo ideas for a client, and one of them was the best thing she'd drawn in months.

It wasn't the bus. It was the two hours with nothing else in them.

Two kinds of work

The writer and computer scientist Cal Newport draws a useful line between two kinds of work.

Deep work is focused, demanding thinking done without distraction, the kind that stretches your abilities and produces something of real value. Writing an essay, designing a product, solving a difficult problem, learning a hard skill, analyzing data, planning a project, practicing an instrument.

Shallow work is the logistical, low-concentration work that can be done while distracted. Answering routine emails, filling in forms, scheduling meetings, most chat messages, tidying files.

Both matter. Shallow work keeps your job and life running. But deep work is where most of the value comes from. It's what moves your goals forward, builds your skills and produces work you're proud of. And it's exactly the kind of work that suffers most from interruptions, switching and constant availability.

The trouble is that shallow work is louder. It arrives with notifications and deadlines and people waiting. Deep work rarely has anyone chasing it. So unless you protect it on purpose, shallow work fills the day and deep work happens only in the cracks, if at all.

Attention residue

In 2009, the management researcher Sophie Leroy published a study with a memorable title: "Why is it so hard to do my work?"

She had people work on one task, then switch to another. Sometimes they had finished the first task before switching; sometimes they hadn't. Those who switched away from an unfinished task performed worse on the second one. Part of their attention stayed with the first task, still thinking about it, still wondering how it would turn out. Leroy called this attention residue.

Think about what that means for a normal working day. You're writing a report. You glance at your email "just quickly" and see a message from a client. You don't reply, you go back to the report, but now part of your mind is drafting the reply. Ten minutes later you check the team chat. Someone has asked a question. You answer it and go back to the report, but part of you is wondering whether your answer was right.

Each check leaves a little residue. By lunchtime you've done hours of "work" on the report with only part of your mind present.

Single-tasking

The answer is single-tasking: doing one thing at a time, fully, until it's finished or until a planned break.

That sounds obvious, but for many people it's a radical change. It means not checking email while you write. Not answering messages during a lecture. Not having a video on while you study. Not reading the news while you're on a call.

Single-tasking feels slower at first. It isn't. You'll make fewer mistakes, think more clearly, and finish tasks in less total time, because you're not paying the switching cost over and over.

It also feels better. Many people describe an unexpected sense of calm when they first work on one thing with nothing else pulling at them. The constant background hum of *I should check… I need to reply… what about…* goes quiet.

Make deep work a fixed appointment

The most reliable way to protect deep work is to schedule it like an appointment and treat it as one.

Choose a regular time when you'll do your most demanding work. For many people, mornings work best, before the day's demands pile up and while energy is high. For others, especially night owls, it's late evening. Choose based on your own energy, not on what productivity articles say.

Then block it in your calendar. If your calendar is shared at work, give the block a name that others will respect, such as "Project

planning" or "Report writing", and mark yourself as busy.

Consistency helps a lot. If deep work happens at the same time every day, it becomes a habit and you no longer need to decide each morning whether to do it. Daniel's 8:00 to 8:45 block, before email, became so automatic within a month that he felt strange on days he couldn't do it.

How much deep work is realistic? For most people, somewhere between one and four hours a day. Even very successful writers, scientists and artists often say they do only three or four hours of their hardest thinking a day. If you currently manage none, aim for one block of forty-five to ninety minutes. That alone can change what you achieve in a year.

Batch the shallow work

If deep work gets fixed blocks, shallow work gets batches.

Instead of answering email as it arrives, choose two to four times a day to deal with it all at once. Instead of returning calls throughout the day, return them all at 4 p.m. Instead of doing small admin tasks whenever they occur to you, keep a list and do them together in a single half-hour block.

Batching reduces switching, because you're doing similar tasks together. It also shrinks the total time shallow work takes. Twenty emails answered in one sitting take far less time than twenty emails answered one at a time across the day, each with its own switch in and out.

There's some direct evidence that this helps. In a 2015 study, Kostadin Kushlev and Elizabeth Dunn at the University of British Columbia asked people to check their email only three times a day

for one week, and as often as they liked in another week. During the limited week, people reported significantly less daily stress, and lower stress in turn went along with greater well-being.

Handling other people's expectations

The biggest worry most people have about batching is how others will react. "If I don't reply within ten minutes, my boss will think I'm slacking." "My clients expect instant answers."

Sometimes that's true. Some jobs genuinely need fast replies, and Chapter 19 looks at how to find focus in those jobs. But often the expectation is weaker than we assume. Many people reply instantly not because anyone demands it, but because they've trained everyone, including themselves, to expect it.

A few things help:

- **Tell people your rhythm.** "I check email at 9, 12 and 4. If something's urgent, call me." Most people will adapt.
- **Use status messages.** Set your chat status to "Focusing until 11, will reply after" during deep work.
- **Agree on what urgent means.** With your manager or team, decide which kinds of things need an immediate response and how they'll reach you (usually a phone call), so that everything else can wait.
- **Be reliable in your windows.** If you say you'll reply by 4, reply by 4. Trust grows when people see that waiting works.

Amira set up an automatic reply on her shop's messages: "Thanks for getting in touch! I reply to messages twice a day, at around 11 a.m. and 5 p.m. For urgent order problems, please email or-

ders@…" She worried customers would be annoyed. Instead, a few told her they liked knowing when to expect an answer.

Before you switch, leave a note

Sometimes you have to stop a task before it's finished. The meeting starts, the child wakes up, the day ends. Attention residue will follow you out of the task unless you give your mind a reason to let go.

Before you switch, take one minute to write a short note: where you've got to, what the next step is, and anything you need to remember. "Finished section 2. Next: write the paragraph on costs, using the figures in the green folder. Check the March number with Priya."

Two things happen. First, your mind can let go, because it knows the information is safe. Second, when you come back, you can pick up in seconds instead of minutes, because the next step is waiting for you.

The deep-work ritual

Many people who do a lot of deep work use a short ritual to get started. It doesn't need to be elaborate. The point is to signal to your mind, in the same way each time, that deep work is beginning.

A ritual might include:

- A fixed place (Chapter 7).
- A drink, such as a cup of tea or coffee, made the same way.
- Putting the phone in its home and switching on a focus mode.
- Closing everything on the computer except what's needed.

- Writing down the target for this session.
- Starting a timer.

It takes three or four minutes. After a few weeks, the ritual itself starts to bring on a focused state, the way brushing your teeth at night starts to make you feel sleepy.

Single-tasking outside work

Single-tasking isn't only for work. Try it in the rest of your life too.

Eat a meal without a screen. Have a conversation with your phone in your pocket, not on the table. Watch a film without scrolling through your phone at the same time. Walk without headphones. Play with your children without checking messages.

These moments train the same skill: being fully where you are. They also tend to make the experience itself richer. Food tastes better when you notice it. Conversations go deeper when the other person has your full attention. And relationships improve when the people you love stop competing with a screen.

Try this today

Plan and protect one block of deep work for tomorrow.

1. Choose the most important piece of demanding work you're facing right now.
2. Choose a time tomorrow, ideally when your energy is highest, and block 45 to 90 minutes in your calendar. Give it a clear name.
3. Write down what you want to achieve in that block.
4. Decide your ritual: where you'll sit, what you'll drink, where your phone will go, what you'll close.

5. Choose two or three times tomorrow when you'll check email and messages, and write them down.
6. If you need to, tell one or two people about your new rhythm.

Tomorrow, do the block. When it ends, write a one-line note about how it went.

Reflection

- How much of my average day is deep work, and how much is shallow?
- When am I usually interrupted, and by whom (including myself)?
- What would change in my work or studies if I did one hour of deep work every day for a year?

Part Three: Plan time that holds

Good intentions need a place in the calendar. These five chapters cover choosing what matters, planning realistic days, starting hard tasks and working in a rhythm you can keep.

Chapter 9: Decide what matters

On Monday morning, Daniel wrote out everything he needed to do that week. It took him twenty minutes and filled two pages: forty-seven items. Approve timesheets. Prepare slides for Thursday's review. Reply to the supplier about the delayed shipment. Book the dentist. Read the new security policy. Draft the project plan. Fix the shelf in his son's room. Call his mother. Update his LinkedIn profile. Finish the online compliance course. On and on.

He looked at the list and felt something between panic and exhaustion. Then, because he didn't know where to start, he did what most people do. He picked off the small, quick ones. Booked the dentist. Approved the timesheets. Replied to three emails. By lunchtime he'd crossed off nine items and felt good about it.

The project plan was item number six. It was still there on Friday.

Not all tasks are equal

A to-do list treats every task as the same size and the same importance: a line of text, waiting to be crossed off. Real tasks aren't like that. A few of them matter enormously. Most of them matter a little. Some of them don't matter at all.

When everything looks equal, we tend to choose by ease and urgency: the quick things, the things someone's waiting for, the things with a deadline today. That feels productive. You get to cross things off. But it means the big, important, non-urgent work keeps

getting pushed down the list until it becomes urgent, usually at the worst possible moment.

Researchers have a name for part of this. In a set of studies published in 2018, Meng Zhu, Yang Yang and Christopher Hsee found that people often chose to do urgent tasks with short deadlines over important tasks with bigger rewards, even when the important task was clearly the better choice. They called it the mere urgency effect. Urgency grabs us, whether or not it deserves to.

So the first job of any focus system is to decide what matters, on purpose, before the day decides for you.

The urgent-important matrix

In a 1954 speech, the American president Dwight Eisenhower quoted a former college president: "I have two kinds of problems, the urgent and the important. The urgent are not important, and the important are never urgent." Decades later, Stephen Covey and other writers turned that idea into a simple four-box tool, which is now often called the Eisenhower matrix.

Every task can be sorted by two questions: *Is it important?* (Does it move forward something I care about, or prevent a serious problem?) and *Is it urgent?* (Does it need attention now, or very soon?)

That gives four groups.

1. Important and urgent. Crises, real deadlines, problems that can't wait. A client's urgent request, an exam tomorrow, a burst pipe, a sick child. *Do these now.* But notice how many of them were once important and not urgent, and became urgent because they were left too long.

2. Important but not urgent. The work that builds your future: learning, planning, exercise, relationships, long projects, preventing problems before they happen. Daniel's project plan. Tariq's coding course. Sana's revision three weeks before the exam. *Schedule these.* This is the group that gets neglected, and it's where the biggest gains are.

3. Urgent but not important. Many interruptions, many emails, many meetings, many requests that feel pressing because someone else wants them now. *Limit, batch or delegate these.* Ask whether they need to be done at all, whether someone else could do them, and whether they could be done more quickly or less often.

4. Neither urgent nor important. Mindless scrolling, unnecessary tidying, busywork you do to avoid real work. *Drop these, or keep them for genuine leisure.* Note that leisure itself is not in this group. Rest you choose on purpose is important. It's the drifting, unchosen time that belongs here.

Most people spend far too much time in groups 3 and 4, and far too little in group 2. The aim of the matrix isn't to sort every task perfectly. It's to make the second group visible, so you can give it time before it turns into the first.

The 80/20 rule

At the end of the nineteenth century, the Italian economist Vilfredo Pareto noticed that around 80 percent of the land in Italy was owned by about 20 percent of the people. Later, others noticed similar imbalances almost everywhere: a small share of causes producing a large share of the results. It's now usually called the Pareto principle, or the 80/20 rule.

The numbers aren't exact or universal. Sometimes it's 90/10, sometimes 70/30. But the pattern is common enough to be useful. A small share of your tasks probably produces most of your results. A small share of your study methods probably produces most of your learning. A few of Amira's clients bring in most of her income. A few of Daniel's projects matter most to his director.

To use it, ask these questions about your work:

- *Which few tasks produce most of the value I create?*
- *Which few activities cause most of my stress or wasted time?*
- *If I could only do 20 percent of my list this week, which items would I choose?*

Then put more of your best time into the first group, and look hard at the second.

The one most important task

Even with the matrix and the 80/20 rule, a long list can still feel overwhelming. So here's the simplest tool in this chapter, and possibly the most useful.

Each day, choose one task, just one, that would make the day a success if it were the only thing you did. Some people call it the MIT, for "most important task". Do it first, or at least before you do anything urgent-but-unimportant.

The question to ask is: *What's the one thing I could do today that would make everything else easier or less necessary?* That's the question the writer Gary Keller built a whole book around, and it cuts through a lot of noise.

Daniel's answer, every day for two weeks, was "the next section of the project plan". Sana's answer was usually "one past-paper ques-

tion, done properly". Tariq's was "one lesson of the course, with the exercises". Amira's varied: some days it was a design, some days a difficult email to a client.

On busy days, the MIT might be all you manage of your important work. That's fine. One important thing done every day adds up to more than three hundred a year.

Eat the frog

There's a saying, often attributed to Mark Twain although nobody has found good evidence he said it, that if you eat a live frog first thing in the morning, nothing worse will happen to you the rest of the day. The productivity writer Brian Tracy used the idea as the title of a book: *Eat That Frog!*

The frog is the task you're most likely to put off, usually because it's difficult or unpleasant, and often because it's important. Do it first, before your energy fades and before the day's urgent demands crowd in. Once it's done, the rest of the day feels lighter.

This doesn't suit everyone. Some people need a quick, easy win to get going, a warm-up before the frog. That's fine too. The principle is simply not to let the hardest important task drift to the end of the day, where it's easiest to postpone.

The not-to-do list

Deciding what matters means deciding what doesn't. Many people find it helps to write that down too.

A not-to-do list is a list of things you've decided to stop doing, or not to start. It might include:

- Checking email before my most important task.

- Accepting meetings without an agenda.
- Watching videos on my phone in bed.
- Agreeing to new projects without checking my calendar first.
- Rewriting emails more than twice.
- Saying yes to every favor asked in the group chat.

Look at your not-to-do list every morning for a few weeks. It's a reminder that every yes to something unimportant is a no to something that matters.

Learning to say no

Some of the biggest drains on your focus aren't tasks you choose. They're requests from other people: a colleague who needs help, a friend who wants a favor, a committee looking for volunteers, a client asking for "just one small change".

Many of these deserve a yes. Generosity and helping others are part of a good life. But if you say yes to everything, you'll have nothing left for your own priorities, and people will learn that your time is always available.

A few phrases make saying no easier:

- "I'd like to help, but I can't take that on this month."
- "I can't do that, but I could do this smaller part of it."
- "Let me check my calendar and get back to you tomorrow." (This gives you time to decide properly, instead of agreeing on the spot.)
- "If I take this on, what should I drop?" (Useful with a manager who keeps adding work.)

You don't owe anyone a long explanation. A polite, clear no is kinder in the long run than a reluctant yes followed by resentment or a missed deadline.

Big rocks first

There's a familiar picture, popularized by Stephen Covey, that's worth keeping in mind. Imagine a jar, a pile of big rocks, some gravel, some sand and some water. If you pour in the sand and water first, the big rocks won't fit. If you put the big rocks in first, the gravel, sand and water fill the spaces around them, and everything fits.

The big rocks are your important tasks. The sand is the small, urgent, endless stuff. Put the rocks in first, by scheduling them, and the small things will usually find their place. Leave the rocks until last, and there'll be no room.

Daniel's new Monday

The next Monday, Daniel still wrote his full list. But then he did three things with it.

First, he sorted it into the four groups of the matrix. That took ten minutes and was surprisingly revealing. Only four of his forty-seven items were truly important and not urgent, and the project plan was the biggest. Eleven items were neither urgent nor important; he crossed out seven of them on the spot.

Second, he chose his big rocks for the week: the project plan, preparing for Thursday's review, and one conversation with his director about his workload. He blocked time for each in his calendar.

Third, he wrote his MIT for Monday on a card: "Project plan: draft the risks section." He did it before opening email.

He finished the project plan on Wednesday, two days ahead of the deadline. The forty other items didn't all get done. Most of them didn't need to be.

Try this today

Sort your list.

1. Write down everything you need or want to do in the next week. Get it all out of your head.
2. Next to each item, write 1, 2, 3 or 4, according to the urgent-important groups.
3. Cross out or delegate as many items in group 4 (and group 3) as you honestly can.
4. Choose up to three big rocks from group 2 for this week and schedule a time for each in your calendar.
5. Choose your one most important task for tomorrow. Write it on a card or a sticky note and put it where you'll see it first thing.
6. Start a not-to-do list with at least three items.

Reflection

- Which of the four groups do I spend most of my time in?
- What important but non-urgent task have I been neglecting the longest?
- Who or what do I most need to say no to, and how will I say it?

Chapter 10: Plan the day you'll actually live

Sana's study timetable was a thing of beauty. She'd made it on a Sunday evening, color-coded, in a spreadsheet: every hour of every day for three weeks before her exams, each one assigned to a subject. Pharmacology from 8 to 10. Chemistry from 10 to 12. Lunch. Physiology from 1 to 3. And so on, until 10 p.m., every day, including weekends.

By Tuesday it had collapsed. She'd overslept on Monday and was an hour behind before she started. A lab session she'd forgotten about took up Tuesday afternoon. A friend's birthday dinner swallowed Tuesday evening. By Wednesday the timetable was so far out of date that looking at it only made her feel guilty, so she stopped looking at it.

The problem wasn't that Sana planned. The problem was that she planned a day no human being could live.

Why plans fail

Most daily plans fail for one of four reasons.

They're too full. Every hour is assigned, with no room for travel, meals, rest, interruptions or things taking longer than expected.

They're too optimistic. Each task gets the time it would take on a perfect day, with no problems, no tiredness and no distractions.

They're too vague. "Study" or "work on project" doesn't tell you what to actually do when you sit down.

They're too rigid. When one thing goes wrong, the whole plan falls apart, and there's no easy way to adjust.

The planning methods in this chapter are designed to avoid all four.

The planning fallacy

The second problem, optimism, is so common that psychologists have a name for it. In the 1970s Daniel Kahneman and Amos Tversky described the planning fallacy: our tendency to underestimate how long tasks will take, even when we know from experience that similar tasks took longer in the past.

In a well-known study published in 1994, Roger Buehler, Dale Griffin and Michael Ross asked psychology students to estimate when they'd finish their final-year theses. On average, they predicted about 34 days. The actual average was about 56 days. Most of them finished later than they had predicted, and even when asked for a worst-case estimate, many of them still finished later than that.

We plan for the best case and then live in the normal one. So a good plan builds in that gap from the start.

A rough rule many people find useful: estimate how long a task will take, then add 50 percent. If you think the report will take two hours, give it three. If you finish early, that's a bonus. Over a few weeks, compare your estimates with what actually happened, and adjust.

Time blocking

Time blocking means giving your tasks a place in your calendar, not just a place on a list. Instead of "draft project plan" floating on a to-do list, you have "9:00 to 10:30: draft project plan, risks section" in your calendar, like a meeting with yourself.

This does several things at once. It forces you to be realistic, because you can see how much time you actually have. It protects your important work from being swallowed by other demands, because the time is already taken. And it removes a lot of deciding during the day, because the plan has already decided what's next.

You don't need to block every minute. In fact, you shouldn't. A good time-blocked day has:

- **One to three blocks for important work**, usually your deep work and your MIT.
- **One or two blocks for shallow work**, such as email, messages and admin, batched together.
- **Fixed commitments**: classes, meetings, appointments.
- **Breaks and meals**, actually written in.
- **Buffer time**: empty blocks of 30 to 60 minutes, spread through the day, for the things that run over or come up unexpectedly.

The buffer is what makes the plan survive. When the meeting runs long or a task takes longer than you thought, you move the next block into the buffer instead of throwing away the whole plan.

Timeboxing

Timeboxing is a close cousin of time blocking. The difference is emphasis. Time blocking says *when* you'll work on something.

Timeboxing says *how long* you're willing to spend on it, and then you stop.

This is useful for tasks that tend to expand. In 1955, the historian Cyril Northcote Parkinson wrote a humorous essay in *The Economist* that began, "It is a commonplace observation that work expands so as to fill the time available for its completion." That's now known as Parkinson's law, and you've probably seen it in action. Given a week to write a two-page report, many people will take a week. Given an afternoon, they'll take an afternoon.

So for tasks that don't need to be perfect, give them a box. "I'll spend 30 minutes on these emails." "I'll give the presentation slides 90 minutes." "I'll research website platforms for one hour, then choose." When the time's up, you finish what you're doing and move on.

Timeboxing is especially useful for perfectionists like Amira. It's much easier to stop polishing when the decision has already been made.

A daily plan in ten minutes

Here's a simple routine for planning a day. Do it either the evening before (many people prefer this, because it means the next morning starts with a clear plan) or first thing in the morning, before you check messages.

1. **Look at your calendar.** Note your fixed commitments for the day.
2. **Choose your MIT** (Chapter 9). What's the one task that would make this a good day?

3. **Choose up to two other important tasks**, if there's realistically room.
4. **Block time for them**, with the 50 percent rule. Put the MIT in your best-energy slot.
5. **Block one or two windows for shallow work**: email, messages, admin.
6. **Add breaks, meals and at least one buffer block.**
7. **Write down a clear target for each important block.** Not "work on essay" but "write the paragraph on side effects, about 300 words".
8. **Check the plan against reality.** Does it leave room to breathe? If not, remove something.

Some people do this on paper, some in a calendar app. It doesn't matter much. What matters is that you do it every day, until it becomes as automatic as brushing your teeth.

Capture everything else

Planning one day well is much easier when you're not also trying to remember everything else.

David Allen, in his book *Getting Things Done*, makes a point that many people find freeing: your mind is a poor place to store tasks. When you try to remember everything you need to do, your mind keeps reminding you, at random times, usually when you're trying to concentrate on something else. That's the same effect you met in Chapter 4, where unfinished goals intrude on your thoughts until you make a plan for them.

The answer is to capture. Keep one trusted place, a notebook, a notes app or a simple list, where every task, idea and commitment

goes the moment it appears. Then, once a day or once a week, go through it and decide what to do with each item: do it, schedule it, hand it to someone else, or delete it.

The key word is trusted. If you only write down some things, or you never look at the list, your mind won't trust it and will keep nagging. If you capture everything and review it regularly, your mind can let go.

When the day goes wrong

It will. The question is how to recover without abandoning the plan entirely.

When something knocks the day off course, take two minutes to replan. Look at what's left of the day. Ask: *What's the most important thing I can still do?* Move it into the next available block. Drop or postpone the least important things. Use the buffer.

Don't try to catch up by working late every time. That leads to tiredness, which makes the next day worse. If you consistently can't fit your plan into a reasonable day, the plan is too big. Make tomorrow's smaller.

And if a whole day goes badly, write it off and start fresh tomorrow. One bad day doesn't ruin anything. A week of guilt about one bad day does. (Chapter 15 has much more on recovering from setbacks.)

Plan the week too

Daily plans work best inside a weekly view. Once a week, ideally on the same day each week, spend twenty to thirty minutes looking at the week ahead:

- What are my big rocks this week?
- When will I work on each one?
- What fixed commitments do I have?
- Where are the gaps, and where are the crunch points?

Then, each day, your daily plan simply picks up the next piece. Chapter 20 has a full weekly review routine.

Sana's second timetable

Sana's second attempt looked very different from the first.

Instead of planning every hour, she planned three study blocks a day, each fifty minutes, with ten-minute breaks: one in the morning, one in the afternoon, one in the early evening. On days with labs or lectures, she planned two. Each block had a specific target, written the night before: "Pharmacology: practice questions on anticoagulants, 15 questions, check answers." The rest of the day was left open for classes, meals, friends, rest and catching up.

She also left Sunday afternoon empty, as a buffer for anything that hadn't fitted during the week.

"It felt like far too little," she said. "Two or three hours a day, when everyone else was saying they were studying for ten. But I actually did the two or three hours, every day. And by the exams I'd covered everything, which never happened with the color-coded version."

Try this today

Plan tomorrow in ten minutes, using the routine above.

1. Write down your fixed commitments.

2. Choose your MIT and up to two other important tasks.
3. Estimate the time each will take, then add 50 percent.
4. Block them into your calendar or a paper schedule, with the MIT in your best-energy slot.
5. Add one or two windows for shallow work, your breaks and meals, and at least one buffer block.
6. Write a specific target for each important block.
7. Look at the whole plan and ask, honestly: *Could a normal, tired human being do this?* If not, remove something.

Tomorrow evening, compare what you planned with what happened. Note where your estimates were wrong.

Reflection

- When my plans fail, which of the four reasons is usually to blame?
- Which task in my life most obviously follows Parkinson's law?
- Where do I currently store my tasks, and do I trust it?

Chapter 11: Start before you feel ready

Tariq's course had a project at the end of the fourth module: build a small working web application of your own design. He had been looking forward to it for weeks. When he reached it, he froze.

He didn't know what to build. When he picked an idea, a tool to help his son track football training, he didn't know where to begin. Should he design the screens first? Set up the database? Read more tutorials? Every evening he opened his laptop, thought about all of it at once, felt overwhelmed and closed it again. Four evenings passed like that.

On the fifth evening his daughter, who was fifteen and had no patience for any of this, looked over his shoulder and said, "Just make a button that says hello."

He laughed. Then he made a button that said hello. It took nine minutes. Then he made it say hello to a name you typed in. Then he made a list of names. By the end of the evening he had the first rough piece of the training tracker working, and he went to bed happier than he'd been all week.

Starting is the hardest part

For most important tasks, the hardest moment isn't the middle or the end. It's the beginning. Starting means facing the blank page,

the unfamiliar problem, the uncomfortable feeling you met in Chapter 2. Once you've started, momentum usually carries you. Getting from zero to one is the hard part.

That's why so many of the most useful focus techniques are really starting techniques. They don't make the whole task easy. They make the first step easy enough that you take it.

Find the next physical action

David Allen, whose capture system you met in Chapter 10, makes a simple observation: many tasks on our lists aren't really tasks. They're projects. "Plan holiday", "write essay", "build web app", "sort out finances". You can't do a project. You can only do the next physical action of a project.

The next physical action is the very next visible thing you'd actually do. Not "plan holiday" but "text my sister to ask which week she's free". Not "write essay" but "open a document and type three possible titles". Not "sort out finances" but "log in to the bank and download last month's statement".

When a task feels heavy, ask: *What's the very next physical thing I'd do to move this forward?* Write that down instead of the big task. Often the heaviness lifts immediately, because the next action is something you obviously know how to do.

The two-minute start

There are two popular "two-minute rules", and both are useful.

The first comes from David Allen: if a task will take less than two minutes, do it now instead of writing it down. Reply to the quick email, put the dish in the dishwasher, sign the form.

The second, used by writers such as James Clear, is about starting bigger tasks: make the first step of any habit or task take less than two minutes. Not “study for an hour” but “open my notes and read the first heading”. Not “go for a run” but “put on my running shoes”. Not “write the report” but “write one sentence”.

The trick is that once you’ve done the two-minute start, you’re allowed to stop. Usually you won’t. But the permission to stop is what makes starting feel safe.

The ten-minute agreement

If two minutes is too short to get going, make an agreement with yourself: you’ll work on the task for ten minutes, and then you’ll decide whether to continue.

You met this idea in Chapter 2. It works because procrastination is driven by the expected unpleasantness of a task, and the expectation is usually worse than the reality. Ten minutes in, the task almost always feels more manageable than it did from the outside. And if it doesn’t, you’ve still done ten minutes, which is ten more than you’d have done otherwise.

If-then plans

This is one of the best-researched techniques in this whole book, and it’s very simple.

An if-then plan, which psychologists call an implementation intention, links a specific situation to a specific action. Instead of “I’ll study more”, you decide: *If it’s 7 p.m. on a weekday, then I’ll sit at my desk and open my pharmacology notes.* Instead of “I’ll stop checking my phone”, you decide: *If I feel the urge to check my*

phone during a focus session, then I'll write the urge on my parking page and keep working.

The psychologist Peter Gollwitzer has studied these plans since the 1990s. In 2006, he and Paschal Sheeran reviewed 94 independent tests and found that forming if-then plans had a medium-to-large effect on whether people reached their goals. In a much larger review published in 2024, Sheeran, Gollwitzer and Olivia Listrom analyzed 642 tests. They again found if-then plans helpful across a wide range of goals, and the effects were larger when the plan used a true if-then format, when people were strongly motivated, and when they rehearsed the plan at least once.

Why do they work? A vague intention leaves the decision for later, and later is when you're tired, distracted and tempted. An if-then plan makes the decision now, while you're clear-headed. When the situation arrives, the action is already chosen. You don't have to deliberate; you just follow the plan.

To make a good if-then plan:

1. **Choose a specific cue.** A time ("at 7 p.m."), a place ("when I sit on the train"), or an event ("after I finish dinner", "when I open my laptop").
2. **Choose a specific action.** Something concrete and small enough to actually do.
3. **Write it in the form "If..., then I will..."**
4. **Say it to yourself once or twice**, or picture yourself doing it.

You can use if-then plans for starting ("If it's 8:00 a.m., then I'll open the project plan before my email") and for obstacles ("If a colleague asks me to join a meeting during my focus block, then I'll suggest a time after 11").

The ugly first draft

A lot of hesitation at the start of a task comes from wanting the first attempt to be good. That's almost impossible. First attempts are usually bad. That's what they're for.

Give yourself explicit permission to make the first version ugly. Write the essay badly, quickly, with gaps and notes to yourself like "[find a better example here]". Sketch the design roughly. Write the code that barely works. The writer Anne Lamott, in her book *Bird by Bird*, gave this kind of draft a famously rude name and argued that every good writer produces one. Generations of writers have found that idea freeing.

Once you have something, anything, on the page, you're no longer creating from nothing. You're improving, and improving is much easier and much less frightening.

Amira now starts every client proposal by writing the worst possible version in fifteen minutes, with the timer on. "Half of it ends up being fine," she said. "The other half I fix. But I'm never staring at a blank page anymore."

Break the task into steps

Some tasks are so big that even the next action isn't obvious. In that case, spend ten minutes breaking the whole thing down.

Write the task at the top of a page. Below it, list the main parts. Below each part, list the steps. Keep going until each step is something you could do in one session of thirty to sixty minutes. Then put the steps in order.

Tariq's web app, broken down, looked something like this:

- Decide what the app does: list three features.

- Sketch the main screen on paper.
- Build a page with a form to add a training session.
- Save the sessions so they're still there after a refresh.
- Show a list of past sessions.
- Add a simple chart of sessions per week.
- Make it look decent.
- Ask my son to test it.

Nothing on that list was frightening. Each item was one or two evenings' work. The whole project, which had felt impossible, now felt like a series of small, clear steps.

Stop in the middle

Here's a technique for making tomorrow's start easier: don't finish today.

Ernest Hemingway described his own habit in a 1935 magazine article: "The best way is always to stop when you are going good and when you know what will happen next. If you do that every day when you are writing a novel you will never be stuck."

When you end a work session, stop somewhere you know how to continue. Leave a sentence half-written. Leave the next step obvious. Write a short note, as you learned in Chapter 8, about exactly what comes next. Then tomorrow, instead of facing a cold start, you begin by finishing something you already understand. The momentum carries you into the harder part.

Lower the bar on bad days

Some days, even the two-minute start feels like too much. You're tired, stressed or low. On those days, lower the bar even further,

but don't remove it entirely.

Decide on a minimum version of your important habit: the smallest amount that still counts. For Sana, it was "do one practice question". For Tariq, "open the course and watch one video". For Daniel, "write three bullet points for the plan". For Amira, "open the client file and look at it for five minutes".

The minimum keeps the chain going. It reminds you that you're someone who does this, even on bad days. And quite often, once you've done the minimum, you find you have more in you than you thought.

Try this today

Choose one task you've been putting off, and use three starting techniques on it.

1. **Find the next physical action.** Write down the very next visible thing you'd do.
2. **Write an if-then plan** for when you'll do it: "If it's [time/place/event], then I will [next action]."
3. **Do a two-minute start** right now, or at the time in your plan. Set a timer for two minutes and do only the next action. When the timer ends, decide whether to continue for another ten minutes.

Then, for one important task or habit, write down its minimum version for bad days.

Reflection

- Which task on my list is really a project in disguise?
- What if-then plan would help most with my biggest obstacle?

- Where in my work could I give myself permission to make an ugly first draft?

Chapter 12: Work sessions and breaks

In the late 1980s, an Italian university student named Francesco Cirillo was struggling to study. He was distracted, he procrastinated, and he felt he was getting nowhere. So he made a small bet with himself: could he study, really study, for just ten minutes?

To keep himself honest, he used a kitchen timer shaped like a tomato. *Pomodoro* is Italian for tomato. Over time, the ten minutes became twenty-five, followed by a short break, and the system he developed around that timer became one of the best-known productivity methods in the world: the Pomodoro Technique.

The method's success isn't really about tomatoes, or even about twenty-five minutes. It's about something simpler. Work goes better when it comes in sessions with clear edges, separated by real breaks.

The Pomodoro Technique

In its classic form, the technique works like this:

1. Choose a task.
2. Set a timer for 25 minutes. That's one "pomodoro".
3. Work on the task, and only that task, until the timer rings.
4. Take a 5-minute break.
5. After four pomodoros, take a longer break of 15 to 30 minutes.

Cirillo added a few rules that are easy to overlook but make a big difference. A pomodoro can't be split. If you're interrupted and have to stop, it doesn't count, and you start a fresh one later. If a distracting thought or task comes up, you write it down and return to work, as you learned in Chapter 4. And at the end of each day, you look back at how many pomodoros you completed and what got in the way.

The technique works well for many people for reasons you've already met in this book. The task is clear. The time is short enough that starting doesn't feel threatening. The timer gives you a boundary, so resisting distractions is easier because a break is always close. And the record of completed pomodoros gives you a simple measure of real, focused work.

Not everyone's number is 25

Twenty-five minutes is a good starting point, but it isn't magic. Some people find it too short. Just as they're getting into the work, the timer rings. Others find it too long, especially at first. And different kinds of work need different rhythms.

Here are some common patterns. Try a few and see which fits you.

25 and 5. The classic. Good for getting started, for tasks you tend to avoid, for revision and admin, and for days when your focus is weak.

50 and 10. Popular with people who find 25 minutes too short. Good for writing, coding, design and other work that needs time to warm up.

75 to 90, then 15 to 20. For deep work by people who have built up their focus (rung five on the focus ladder in Chapter 5). Good

for complex problems and creative work. Not usually sustainable more than two or three times a day.

Work until a natural stopping point. Some people prefer to work without a fixed timer and take a break when they reach a natural pause or notice their focus fading, then note how long the session was. This suits people who are already good at focusing and dislike being interrupted by an alarm.

You can mix them, too. Many people use short sessions in the morning to get going and longer ones once they've warmed up, or longer sessions for creative work and short ones for admin.

Breaks are part of the work

People who are trying to get more done often skip breaks, or feel guilty for taking them. That's a mistake.

Attention is tiring. If you work for hours without stopping, your focus doesn't stay level. It sags, often without your noticing. You read the same line three times. You make more errors. You start drifting to your phone, which is your mind taking the break you didn't give it, only in a less restful form.

A planned break lets you recover before you reach that point. In 2022, Patricia Albulescu and her colleagues at the West University of Timișoara published a review of 22 experimental studies on micro-breaks, short breaks of ten minutes or less between work tasks. They found that micro-breaks reliably increased people's energy and reduced fatigue, though the effects were modest. Their effect on performance was less clear overall; it showed up mainly for less demanding tasks, and the longer the break, the larger the boost tended to be. Their conclusion was that recovering from very demanding work may need breaks of more than ten minutes.

So breaks help you feel better and keep going, and for hard thinking, a proper break is better than a tiny one.

What makes a good break

Not all breaks are equal. Some leave you refreshed. Others leave you more tired, or pull you away from work for far longer than you meant.

Good breaks tend to give your mind a rest from the kind of effort the work demanded. For most desk work, that means:

- **Moving your body.** Stand up, stretch, walk around the room or the building, climb a flight of stairs.
- **Looking into the distance.** Out of a window, ideally at something green. Your eyes have been focused on a screen or a page a short distance away; let them relax.
- **Getting outside.** Even a few minutes of fresh air and daylight help many people. In a 2008 study, Marc Berman, John Jonides and Stephen Kaplan at the University of Michigan found that people who walked for just under an hour in a park-like arboretum did better on a test of attention afterward than people who walked the same length of time along busy city streets.
- **Drinking water, having a light snack, making tea.**
- **Talking to someone**, briefly, about something unrelated to work.
- **Resting your eyes**, or a few minutes of slow breathing.

Poor breaks tend to be ones that keep your mind busy in the same way, or that are hard to stop:

- **Scrolling social media or watching short videos.** These are hard to stop after five minutes, they keep your eyes on a screen,

and they often leave you with new things to think about (attention residue again) or feeling worse (the comparison problem from Chapter 3).

- **Checking email or work messages.** This isn't a break; it's switching to a different kind of work.
- **Reading the news**, which often leaves people anxious or distracted.

You don't have to be strict about this. A few minutes on your phone is sometimes exactly what you want. But if you notice that your five-minute breaks keep turning into thirty, or that you come back from them feeling worse, try a break with no screen at all.

Protect the break's ending

A break that doesn't end isn't a break. It's the end of the work session.

Set a timer for your breaks as well as your work. When the break timer rings, go back, even if you'd prefer not to. If you find this hard, try deciding the target for the next session before you start the break. Then, when the break ends, you know exactly what to return to, which makes returning easier.

Longer breaks: lunch and the end of the day

Beyond short breaks, two longer ones matter.

Lunch. Many people eat at their desks, often while reading email or scrolling. Taking a real lunch break, away from the desk and preferably away from screens, gives your mind and body a proper rest in the middle of the day. Even twenty or thirty minutes can make the afternoon noticeably better.

The end of the workday. Chapter 17 covers this in detail, but the short version is: stop at a defined time, and do something to mark the end. Without a clear end, work spreads into the evening and you never fully rest.

Choosing your rhythm

To choose the right session length and break pattern, ask four questions.

How long can I currently focus? Use your number from Chapter 5. Start your sessions slightly below it.

What kind of work is this? Creative, complex work tends to benefit from longer sessions. Repetitive or unpleasant tasks often go better in shorter bursts.

How's my energy today? On a tired or stressed day, shorten your sessions. On a strong day, lengthen them.

What does my schedule allow? If you only have forty minutes between classes, one forty-minute session may be better than trying to fit in two short ones.

Daniel found that 50 and 10 suited him best for planning and writing, but that 25 and 5 worked better for the dull admin he tended to avoid. Sana used 25 and 5 for the first fortnight of exam revision, then moved to 45 and 10 as her focus improved. Tariq, coding in the evenings after a full working day, stuck with 25 and 5: two pomodoros on weeknights, four on Saturdays.

Count sessions, not hours

One useful side effect of working in sessions is that it gives you a better way to measure your work.

Hours at a desk are a poor measure. You can sit for three hours and do twenty minutes of real work. Completed sessions are a much better measure, because each one is a period of genuine focus on one thing.

At the end of each day, count your completed sessions. Over a week, you'll see a pattern. Most people are surprised at how few truly focused sessions they used to do, and encouraged by how quickly the number grows once they start paying attention to it. Four good sessions a day, five days a week, is twenty sessions, or around eight to sixteen hours of real focused work depending on their length. For most people, that's more than enough to make serious progress on what matters.

Try this today

Run a rhythm experiment.

1. Choose an important task you'll work on today.
2. Do two sessions of 25 minutes, each followed by a 5-minute break with no screen.
3. Later, or tomorrow, do one session of 50 minutes, followed by a 10-minute break with no screen.
4. After each, note in your log: How focused did I feel? How much did I get done? How did I feel afterward?
5. Compare the two. Which rhythm suited this task better?

During each break, try one of the good-break ideas: a short walk, stretching, looking out of a window, stepping outside.

Reflection

- What do I usually do on my breaks, and how do I feel afterward?

- Which session length feels right for my most important kind of work?
- How many truly focused sessions do I do on a normal day now? What would I like that number to be?

Chapter 13: Do the right things

Amira was proud of how fast she worked. She could turn around a social media graphic in twenty minutes, answer a customer message in thirty seconds, and pack an order in under three minutes. She had keyboard shortcuts for everything. She had once timed herself wrapping prints and shaved a minute off the process.

What she couldn't work out was why, despite all that speed, she was earning less than she had a year ago and working more hours.

When she finally sat down and looked at where her time went, the answer was uncomfortable. She was very efficient at a lot of work that didn't pay. She spent eight hours a week making free graphics for the online shop's social media, which brought in a handful of sales. She spent five hours a week answering questions from customers that were already answered on her website. She spent hours redesigning things that were already fine. Meanwhile, her best-paying work, brand projects for small businesses, got whatever time was left over.

She was doing things right. She just wasn't always doing the right things.

Doing things right versus doing the right things

The management writer Peter Drucker drew this distinction in his 1967 book *The Effective Executive*. Efficiency, he said, is doing things right. Effectiveness is doing the right things.

Both matter. But effectiveness comes first. There's no point doing something efficiently if it shouldn't be done at all. A faster way to do useless work is still useless work.

Most productivity advice is about efficiency: shortcuts, apps, faster methods. This chapter is about effectiveness: making sure the work you're doing is worth doing, and then doing it in the simplest way that works.

Four questions for every recurring task

Look at the tasks that fill your week, especially the ones that come back again and again. For each, ask four questions, in this order.

1. Can I eliminate it? What would happen if you simply stopped? Sometimes the honest answer is "nothing much". Reports that nobody reads. Meetings that don't decide anything. Social media posts that don't bring customers. Tidying that nobody notices. Before you make a task faster, check whether it needs to exist.

2. Can I reduce it? If you can't eliminate it, can you do less of it? Post three times a week instead of daily. Hold the meeting every two weeks instead of weekly. Check email three times a day instead of thirty. Write a one-page summary instead of a ten-page report.

3. Can I hand it over? Can someone else do it, perhaps better or more cheaply? A colleague whose job it really is. A family member. A paid service. A piece of software. Delegating can feel uncomfortable, especially if you like control, but your time is limited, and every hour you spend on something someone else could do is an hour you can't spend on what only you can do.

4. Can I simplify or systematize it? For what's left, find the simplest reliable way. Use a template. Write a checklist. Automate the repetitive parts. Batch it with similar tasks.

Amira went through these questions for every regular task in her week. She stopped making daily social graphics and posted three strong pieces of work a week instead. She rewrote her website's frequently asked questions and added a link to them in her automatic message reply, which cut her customer questions by more than half. She hired a student to pack orders two afternoons a week. And she made a proposal template, which turned a four-hour task into a ninety-minute one. In a month, she'd freed up around twelve hours a week, and she put most of them into brand projects.

Templates and checklists

Any task you do more than a few times is worth a template or a checklist.

A **template** is a ready-made starting point: a document, email or file with the structure already in place. Amira's proposal template had her standard sections, her terms and her pricing table, so each new proposal only needed the details for that client. Daniel made templates for his weekly status report and for meeting agendas. Sana made a template for her revision notes: key idea, how it works, examples, common exam questions.

A **checklist** is a list of steps you follow every time, so you don't have to remember them. The surgeon Atul Gawande, in *The Checklist Manifesto*, describes how simple checklists reduced errors in operating theaters and other complex settings. You don't need to be doing surgery for checklists to help. A checklist for

starting your workday, for packing your bag before an exam, for sending an invoice, or for closing your shop at night removes small decisions and stops small things being forgotten.

Templates and checklists also help with focus, because they reduce the friction of starting (Chapter 11). When the structure is already there, it's much easier to begin.

Batch similar tasks

You met batching in Chapter 8, as a way to deal with email and messages. It works for many other tasks too.

Make all your phone calls in one block. Run all your errands in one trip. Pay all your bills on the same day each month. Cook several meals at once at the weekend. Write several social media posts in one session instead of one a day.

Each time you switch between different kinds of tasks, there's a cost in time and attention. Batching keeps you in one mode for longer and shrinks that cost.

Use technology on purpose

Technology can make you much more effective, or it can eat your time without your noticing.

Useful technology tends to remove repetitive work: calendar reminders, automatic bill payments, email filters that sort messages into folders, text shortcuts for phrases you type often, a password manager, a shared family calendar.

AI assistants are now part of this picture too. They can help you draft a first version of an email, summarize long documents, suggest how to break down a project, or explain a concept you're

stuck on. Used well, that can save real time. But they bring their own trap. It's easy to spend an hour asking a chatbot to make you the perfect study plan, the perfect morning routine, the perfect productivity system, and never start the actual work. Asking an assistant to plan can be another form of the productive procrastination you met in Chapter 2. Use these tools for the parts of a task they help with, check what they give you, and then close them and do the work.

As a rule, before adopting any new app or tool, ask: *What specific problem will this solve, and is that problem worth the time it takes to set up and learn?* Many people have more productivity apps than productive hours.

Good enough

Some tasks deserve your best. Most don't.

An important client proposal, an exam answer, a difficult conversation, your most important creative work: these deserve real care. But a routine email to a colleague, the formatting of an internal document, the color of a folder, the wording of a reminder message: these need to be clear and correct, and that's all.

Perfectionists, like Amira, often spend large amounts of time on small improvements that nobody else will notice. One way to break this habit is to decide in advance, for each task, which level it deserves:

- *Excellent* for work that is important, visible and high-stakes. Give it time and care.
- *Good* for work that needs to be done properly but doesn't need to be outstanding.

- *Done* for work that just needs to exist and work.

Most of your tasks are “good” or “done”. Treating them all as “excellent” is how hours disappear.

Know your best hours

Effectiveness isn’t only about which tasks you do. It’s also about when you do them.

Most people have times of day when they think most clearly, and times when their energy dips. These patterns differ a lot from person to person. Some people are sharpest early in the morning; others don’t really wake up until mid-morning; some do their best thinking late at night. Many people notice a dip in the early afternoon.

For one week, check your energy and focus every two hours or so, on a scale of 1 to 5. Note the time and what you were doing. By the end of the week you’ll have a rough map of your own day.

Then use it. Put your most demanding work, your MIT and your deep work, in your high-energy times. Put shallow work, meetings and admin in your low-energy times. Don’t waste your sharpest hour on email.

Tariq discovered that his worst time for coding was straight after dinner, when he usually tried to do it. His best was early morning, before his family woke up. He moved two of his weekly sessions to 6:00 a.m. on weekdays and found he got more done in forty minutes than he used to in ninety.

Rest is part of effectiveness

One more point, which Part Four develops in detail. Working longer hours doesn't always mean getting more done. Beyond a certain point, extra hours often produce less, because tiredness slows you down, increases mistakes and makes everything feel harder.

Effective people protect their rest for the same reason they protect their deep work: because both are necessary for good results. A tired mind isn't an efficient one.

Try this today

Do an effectiveness review of your week.

1. List the tasks that take up most of your time in a normal week, especially the recurring ones.
2. For each, ask the four questions in order: Can I eliminate it? Reduce it? Hand it over? Simplify or systematize it?
3. Choose one task to eliminate or reduce this week.
4. Choose one recurring task and make a template or checklist for it.
5. For your three most common tasks, decide whether each deserves "excellent", "good" or "done".
6. Start an energy map: for the rest of this week, note your energy level every couple of hours.

Reflection

- Which task in my week am I doing very efficiently, even though it may not need doing at all?

- What do I keep doing myself that someone or something else could do?
- When are my best hours, and what am I currently doing with them?

Part Four: Keep going when motivation fades

Motivation is a good starting fuel and a poor long-distance one. These four chapters are about goals, habits, self-respect and energy: what keeps you moving on ordinary days.

Chapter 14: Goals you can act on

Every January for five years, Tariq had written the same goal at the front of a new notebook: *Change careers. Become a developer.*

Every year it stayed there, underlined, while the year filled up with other things. It wasn't that he didn't want it. He wanted it badly. But the goal was so big and so far away that it never told him what to do on a Tuesday evening. It was a destination with no road.

This year, the course had given him a road of sorts. But he noticed that he still swung between two moods: a rush of excitement whenever he imagined the finish line, and a slump whenever he realized how far away it was. What he needed was a way to turn the big goal into something he could act on every week.

Why big goals stall

Big goals are important. They give your life direction and make the effort feel worthwhile. But on their own, they have three weaknesses.

They're too far away. A goal that's two years off doesn't create any pressure today. The reward is distant, and as you saw in Chapter 2, distant rewards are weak motivators.

They're too vague. "Get fit", "be more productive", "start a business", "do well at university" sound like plans, but they don't say what to do.

They're out of your direct control. Whether you get the job, win the client or pass the exam depends partly on things you can't control: other candidates, the economy, the examiner. If your only goal is the outcome, you can do everything right and still feel like a failure.

The answer is to keep the big goal and build a structure beneath it.

Outcome goals and process goals

It helps to separate two kinds of goals.

An **outcome goal** is the result you want. "Get a job as a junior developer." "Pass my pharmacology exam with a good grade." "Earn twice as much from brand projects this year." "Lose ten kilos."

A **process goal** is what you'll do regularly to make that result more likely. "Code for five sessions a week." "Do fifteen practice questions every weekday." "Send three proposals to potential clients every month." "Walk for thirty minutes every day and cook at home five nights a week."

Outcome goals give you direction. Process goals give you something to do today. And process goals are under your control in a way outcomes aren't. You can't guarantee you'll get the job. You can guarantee you'll code five times this week.

James Clear makes a similar point in *Atomic Habits*: winners and losers often have the same goals. What differs is the system they follow. You don't rise to the level of your goals; you fall to the level of your systems.

Keep both. Write the outcome goal down, so you remember where you're going. Then put most of your attention on the process.

Make it specific

You've probably heard of SMART goals. The idea is usually traced to a 1981 article by George Doran in the journal *Management Review*, and the letters have been used in several slightly different ways since then. A common version is that a good goal is:

- **Specific**: clear about what you'll do or achieve.
- **Measurable**: you can tell whether you've done it.
- **Achievable**: realistic given your time and abilities.
- **Relevant**: connected to something you care about.
- **Time-bound**: it has a deadline or a timeframe.

"Get better at coding" becomes "complete modules five and six of my course, including both projects, by the end of March". "Study more" becomes "do two fifty-minute study sessions every weekday for the next four weeks".

SMART isn't perfect. Applied too rigidly, it can push people toward safe, small goals and away from ambitious ones. But it's a useful check, especially the M and the T. If you can't measure your goal and it has no timeframe, you'll never know whether you're on track.

Milestones: the steps between here and there

Between a big outcome and your daily process, add milestones: checkpoints that break the journey into stages of a few weeks to a few months each.

Tariq's milestones for the next year looked like this:

- **End of March:** finish the course and both projects.

- **End of May:** build two small apps of my own and put them online.
- **End of July:** make a simple portfolio website and ask two developers I know for feedback.
- **End of September:** apply for at least ten junior roles or apprenticeships.
- **End of December:** have a developer job offer, or a clear plan for what to do differently next year.

Each milestone was far enough away to matter and close enough to feel real. Each one told him what to focus on now. And reaching each one gave him a reason to celebrate on the way, instead of waiting two years for a single moment of success.

Deadlines that help

Deadlines are strange. Nobody likes them, and yet many people find they only do serious work when one is close.

In a pair of studies published in 2002, Dan Ariely and Klaus Wertenbroch looked at what happens when people set their own deadlines. In the first, students on a course had to write three papers. In one class they could choose their own due dates; in another the dates were fixed and evenly spaced across the term. Many students who could choose did set themselves early deadlines, which shows they knew they needed them. But the students with fixed, evenly spaced deadlines got better grades. In the second study, people were paid to proofread three long texts over three weeks. Those given evenly spaced deadlines found the most errors and handed in the most work on time, those who set their own deadlines came next, and those with a single deadline at the end did worst.

The lesson: deadlines help, and closer, more regular deadlines help more. If your goal only has a deadline at the end, create your own along the way, and if you can, make them binding by involving someone else. Tell a friend you'll send them your first draft by Friday. Book a mock exam. Schedule a meeting to show your progress.

WOOP: dream, then plan for the obstacle

In Chapter 4 you met Gabriele Oettingen's finding that positive fantasies about the future can reduce effort. Oettingen didn't stop there. She went on to develop and test a method that combines dreaming with realism, which she calls mental contrasting with implementation intentions, or WOOP for short.

WOOP stands for:

- **Wish**: What do you want to achieve? Make it challenging but possible.
- **Outcome**: What's the best result of achieving it? How would it feel? Picture it vividly for a minute.
- **Obstacle**: What's the main thing inside you that might stop you? Not the outside world, but your own habits, feelings or beliefs. Picture it vividly too.
- **Plan**: What will you do when the obstacle appears? Write it as an if-then plan (Chapter 11).

Here's Sana's WOOP for her exam revision:

- **Wish:** Do two focused study sessions every weekday until the exam.
- **Outcome:** I'll walk into the exam feeling prepared, not panicked. I'll actually understand the material, and I'll have my

evenings back the week before.

- **Obstacle:** When I get home tired, I lie on my bed "for a minute" with my phone and lose the evening.
- **Plan:** If I get home after 5 p.m., then I'll go straight to the desk, put my phone in the hallway basket, and start the first session before I sit or lie anywhere else.

The obstacle step is the important one. Dreaming alone gives you a pleasant feeling. Dreaming followed by a hard look at what's in the way, and a plan for it, gives you a reason and a method to act. Oettingen and her colleagues have tested WOOP in many studies with students, patients and working adults, and generally found that it helps people make more progress on their goals than positive thinking alone.

A WOOP takes about five minutes. You can do one for a big goal, or for a single day.

Lead and lag measures

Here's a way of tracking progress that keeps your attention on what you can control.

A **lag measure** tells you about the result, after it's happened: your exam grade, your weight, your monthly income, whether you got the job. It's important, but by the time you see it, it's too late to change.

A **lead measure** tracks the actions that drive the result, while you can still do something about them: number of focused study sessions this week, number of practice questions done, number of proposals sent, number of days you walked, number of coding sessions completed.

Track your lead measures weekly. If they're on target, trust the process even when the lag measures are slow to move. If they're off target, you know exactly what to fix.

Fewer goals, done properly

One of the most common mistakes is having too many goals at once. Learn a language, get fit, start a business, read fifty books, meditate daily, learn guitar, get promoted, save more money. Each one is worthwhile. All of them at once is a recipe for doing none of them well.

Your attention and energy are limited. Every goal competes for them. Choose one to three major goals at a time, at most. Put the others on a "later" list. When one goal is achieved or becomes a settled habit, you can add another.

Should you tell people?

You may have heard that telling people about your goals makes you more likely to achieve them, or the opposite, that it makes you less likely.

The evidence is mixed, and it seems to depend on how you tell them. A 2009 study led by Peter Gollwitzer found that when people announced goals that were tied to their identity ("I'm going to become a lawyer"), and others noticed, they sometimes put in less effort afterward, as if being seen as someone with that goal gave them some of the satisfaction already. On the other hand, telling someone specific about a specific plan, and asking them to check on your progress, can create helpful accountability.

A good rule of thumb: don't announce your dreams for applause. Share your plans with one or two people who'll ask you how

they’re going.

Try this today

Turn one big goal into a plan you can act on.

1. Write down one important outcome goal.
2. Break it into three to five milestones, each with a date.
3. For the first milestone, write one or two process goals: what you’ll do every day or every week.
4. Choose one lead measure you’ll track weekly.
5. Do a WOOP for this week: Wish, Outcome, Obstacle, Plan.
6. Tell one person your plan for the first milestone, and ask them to check on you in two weeks.

Reflection

- What goal have I been carrying around for years without a road beneath it?
- What’s the main obstacle inside me, not outside, that stops me making progress?
- Which goals should I put on a “later” list so I can focus on the one or two that matter most now?

Chapter 15: Discipline without self-punishment

Three weeks into her new study routine, Sana had a bad week. Her grandmother was ill, and the family spent two evenings at the hospital. She caught a cold. A group project fell apart and took two more evenings to fix. By Friday she had done three study sessions out of a planned ten.

On Saturday morning she looked at her log, with its empty boxes, and something in her collapsed. *I always do this,* she thought. *I start something, I do well for a couple of weeks, and then I ruin it. I'm just not a disciplined person.* She didn't study at all that weekend. Why bother, when she'd already failed?

That last thought is the dangerous one. Not the bad week, which was nobody's fault. The conclusion she drew from it.

The trap of all or nothing

Many people treat their plans like a fragile glass. As long as it's perfect, they keep going. The moment it cracks, they throw the whole thing away.

Researchers studying dieting noticed a version of this decades ago. Janet Polivy and Peter Herman found that some dieters, once they'd broken their diet with one forbidden food, went on to eat far more than people who weren't dieting at all, as if they'd

thought, *Well, the day's ruined now, so I might as well.* It's sometimes called the "what-the-hell effect".

The same pattern shows up everywhere. You miss one gym session, so you skip the rest of the week. You check your phone once during a focus block, so you spend the rest of the block scrolling. You have one unproductive day, so you write off the week. One slip turns into a slide, not because of the slip itself but because of the story you tell about it.

Why harshness backfires

Many people believe that being hard on themselves is what keeps them in line. If they went easy on themselves, they think, they'd never get anything done.

The research suggests the opposite, at least for most people.

You met one study in Chapter 2. In 2010, Michael Wohl, Timothy Pychyl and Shannon Bennett followed first-year university students through two exams. Students who forgave themselves for procrastinating before the first exam procrastinated less before the second. The effect worked through feelings. Self-forgiveness reduced the negative emotions linked to the first exam, and with less guilt and shame attached to studying, students were more willing to approach it next time.

In 2012, Juliana Breines and Serena Chen at the University of California, Berkeley, ran a series of experiments on self-compassion after failure. In one, students did poorly on a difficult test. Some were then encouraged to be understanding and kind to themselves about it. Others were given a boost to their self-esteem, and a third group was given no instruction at all. When given the

chance to study for a second test, the self-compassionate group studied longer than the others.

The pattern is consistent. Harsh self-criticism makes tasks feel more threatening, and threatening tasks are the ones we avoid. Kindness toward yourself, combined with honesty about what went wrong, makes it easier to try again.

What self-compassion is, and isn't

The psychologist Kristin Neff, who has done much of the research in this area, describes self-compassion as having three parts:

- **Kindness toward yourself**, especially when you fail or struggle. Talking to yourself the way you'd talk to a good friend in the same situation.
- **Common humanity.** Remembering that everyone fails, struggles and falls short. You're not uniquely flawed.
- **Mindfulness.** Seeing your situation clearly, without ignoring the problem and without exaggerating it.

Self-compassion is not the same as letting yourself off the hook. It doesn't say "it doesn't matter" or "you don't need to change". It says, "This went badly, and that's painful. It happens to everyone. What can I learn, and what will I do next?"

In fact, self-compassion often makes it easier to take responsibility, because owning a mistake is less frightening when you know you won't beat yourself up for it.

The friend test

When you catch yourself in harsh self-talk, try this. Imagine a close friend came to you and described exactly what happened to

you. Same situation, same slip, same disappointment. What would you say to them?

You probably wouldn't say, "You're hopeless. You always ruin everything. You'll never change." You'd say something like, "That sounds like a really hard week. Of course you couldn't study as much. You've done well for three weeks. Let's look at what you can do this week."

Now say that to yourself. It may feel awkward. Say it anyway.

Never miss twice

Here's a simple rule that defuses the all-or-nothing trap: you're allowed to miss once, but try never to miss twice in a row.

Missing one day of a habit has very little effect on your progress. Life happens. You get ill, you travel, there's a family emergency, you're exhausted. One miss is a blip. But two misses in a row starts to become a new pattern, and the habit begins to slip away.

So when you miss, your only job is to make sure the next opportunity happens, even in its minimum version (Chapter 11). Missed your study session on Monday? Do at least one practice question on Tuesday. Missed your morning deep work block? Do twenty minutes in the afternoon. The goal isn't to make up for the miss. It's to keep the chain going.

A reset routine for bad days and bad weeks

When a day or week goes badly, use this short routine to reset, instead of spiraling.

1. Pause and name it. "This was a bad week. I did three study sessions out of ten." Plain and accurate. Not "I'm a failure", just

what happened.

2. Be kind. Use the friend test. Remind yourself that setbacks are normal and that one bad week doesn't erase three good ones.

3. Look for causes, not blame. What actually got in the way? Illness, a family emergency, overcommitment, poor sleep, a plan that was too ambitious, a trigger you didn't see coming? Write down the honest causes.

4. Decide what, if anything, to change. Some causes were one-offs, and nothing needs to change. Others point to a weakness in your plan: maybe it needs more buffer, smaller sessions or a better if-then plan for a recurring obstacle.

5. Choose the next small step. Not a heroic catch-up. Just the next session, the next minimum, the next MIT. Put it in your calendar.

6. Start again. Today, or tomorrow at the latest.

The whole routine takes ten minutes. It turns a setback from a verdict on your character into information about your system.

Use fresh starts

Some moments feel like natural new beginnings: a Monday, the first of the month, a birthday, the start of a new term, the day after a holiday. In 2014, Hengchen Dai, Katherine Milkman and Jason Riis studied what they called the fresh start effect. They found that people were more likely to search for information about dieting, visit the gym and commit to goals right after these kinds of landmarks.

You can use this on purpose. If you've had a bad stretch, choose a fresh start date. It doesn't have to be a big one. Next Monday

works. “Tomorrow is the first day of my new routine” can be a useful story, as long as you don’t use it to postpone everything until a perfect date. The point is to draw a line under the past and give yourself a clean beginning.

Discipline as keeping promises

So what is discipline, if it isn’t being hard on yourself?

One useful way to think about it: discipline is keeping the promises you make to yourself. Not grand promises like “I’ll study eight hours a day”, but small, specific ones like “I’ll do two focus sessions tomorrow” or “I’ll open the document before email”.

Every time you keep one, you build trust with yourself. You become someone whose plans actually happen. Over time, that trust grows into a sense of identity: *I’m the kind of person who does what I say I’ll do.* That identity is much more powerful than willpower, because it doesn’t need to be summoned. It’s just who you are.

This is why it matters to keep your promises small enough to keep. A promise you break teaches you that your plans don’t mean much. A promise you keep, however small, teaches you the opposite.

What Sana did next

On Sunday evening, after a weekend of feeling terrible, Sana called her older brother. He listened, then said, “So you had a family emergency and a cold, and you still did three sessions? That’s not failing. That’s doing well in a bad week.”

She hadn’t seen it that way. She sat down with her log and did the reset routine. The honest causes were obvious: the hospital visits,

the cold, the group project. None of them were about her being undisciplined. But she did notice one thing she could change. Her plan had no buffer at all, so when anything went wrong, she immediately fell behind. She added a buffer block on Sunday afternoons.

Then she did one study session on Sunday evening, just twenty-five minutes, and went to bed. On Monday she did her usual two.

"I'd have given up completely, before," she said. "I've done that so many times. This time I just started again. It felt weird that it was that simple."

Try this today

Rewrite your inner voice.

1. Think of a recent time you fell short of a goal or plan.
2. Write down, word for word, what you said to yourself about it.
3. Now imagine a close friend told you the same story. Write down what you'd say to them.
4. Read the second version out loud, to yourself.
5. Then do the six-step reset routine for that situation: name it, be kind, look for causes, decide what to change, choose the next step, start again.

Finally, write a "never miss twice" plan for your most important habit: what's the minimum version you'll do the day after a miss?

Reflection

- When I slip, what story do I usually tell myself?
- Do I believe harshness keeps me disciplined? What does my own experience actually show?

- What small promise could I make to myself today, and keep?

Chapter 16: Habits that carry you

When Daniel first started his forty-five-minute block before email, every morning was a small fight. His hand drifted toward the email tab. His mind listed all the messages that might be waiting. Some mornings he won the fight and some mornings he lost.

Two months later, something had changed. He'd sit down, make his coffee, open the project file and start working, and only afterward notice that he hadn't thought about email at all. The fight had stopped. Not because he'd become more disciplined, but because the new routine had become a habit.

"It's like brushing my teeth now," he said. "I don't decide to do it. I just do it."

That's the goal of this chapter: to turn the most important parts of your focus system into habits, so they stop costing you willpower every day.

What a habit is

A habit is a behavior that has become automatic in a particular situation. When the situation comes up, you do the behavior without having to decide. You get in the car and put on your seatbelt. You walk into the kitchen in the morning and switch on the kettle. You sit down on the train and take out your phone.

Habits are built through repetition in a stable context. Each time you do the same thing in the same situation, the link between them grows a little stronger, until the situation alone is enough to trigger the behavior.

This is good news and bad news. The bad news is that your current habits, including the unhelpful ones, are well established, because you've repeated them hundreds or thousands of times. The good news is that the same process can build new ones.

How long it takes

You may have heard that it takes 21 days to form a habit. That number has no good scientific basis.

The best-known study on habit formation was published in 2010 by Phillippa Lally and her colleagues at University College London. They asked 96 people to choose a new daily behavior, such as drinking a glass of water after breakfast or going for a run before dinner, and to report each day for twelve weeks how automatic it felt. For the people whose data could be analyzed this way, the median time to reach a plateau of automaticity was 66 days. But the range was huge: from 18 days to 254. Simple behaviors, like drinking water, became automatic faster than complex ones, like doing fifty sit-ups.

Two lessons follow. First, expect habits to take weeks to months, not days. Don't give up after a fortnight because a new routine still feels effortful. Second, the study found that missing a single day didn't seriously damage the process. That's another reason for the "never miss twice" rule from Chapter 15.

The parts of a habit

Writers such as Charles Duhigg and James Clear describe habits as having a few parts. A simple version:

The cue is what triggers the habit: a time, a place, a feeling, a preceding action, or other people.

The routine is the behavior itself.

The reward is what you get from it: pleasure, relief, a sense of completion. The reward is what teaches your brain that the routine is worth repeating.

To build a good habit, you make the cue clear, the routine easy and the reward satisfying. To break a bad one, you do the opposite: hide the cue, make the routine harder and remove or replace the reward.

You've already met many of these ideas. Putting your phone in another room hides a cue. Grayscale weakens a reward. Leaving your notes open on the desk makes a cue obvious. The two-minute start makes a routine easy. This chapter brings them together.

Habit stacking

One of the easiest ways to create a clear cue for a new habit is to attach it to something you already do every day.

The behavior scientist BJ Fogg, in his book *Tiny Habits*, uses a simple formula: "After I [existing habit], I will [new habit]." James Clear calls this habit stacking.

For example:

- After I pour my morning coffee, I'll open my most important task.

- After I sit down on the train, I'll read ten pages of my book.
- After I finish dinner, I'll put my phone in the hallway basket.
- After I close my laptop at the end of work, I'll write tomorrow's MIT on a card.
- After I brush my teeth at night, I'll write three lines in my journal.

The existing habit is already automatic and reliable, so it makes a dependable cue. Choose an anchor that happens at the right time and place for the new habit, and make the new habit small, especially at first. Fogg's advice is to start tiny: floss one tooth, do two push-ups, read one page. Once the habit is established, it will naturally grow.

Make it satisfying

Habits stick when they feel rewarding. The trouble with many good habits is that their rewards are delayed. You study now and see the results in an exam months later. You code tonight and get the job next year. Meanwhile, the bad habits have instant rewards: the video is funny right now.

So add some immediate satisfaction to your good habits.

Track them. A habit tracker, which can be as simple as a calendar where you cross off each day you do the habit, gives you a small, instant reward: the satisfaction of making the mark. Over time, the growing chain of crosses becomes a reward in itself, and you won't want to break it.

Celebrate small wins. BJ Fogg suggests a tiny celebration right after you do a new habit: a fist pump, saying "yes!" or "good job", a

smile. It sounds silly. It's meant to create a small burst of good feeling that your brain links with the habit.

Bundle it with something you enjoy. In Chapter 2's terms, this raises the value of the task. In a study published in 2014, Katherine Milkman, Julia Minson and Kevin Volpp gave some gym members access to gripping audiobooks they could only listen to at the gym. Those members went to the gym more often than people in a comparison group, at least until a holiday break interrupted the routine. Milkman called this temptation bundling. You might allow yourself a favorite podcast only while cleaning, a special coffee only during your deep work block, or a particular playlist only for study sessions.

Make bad habits harder

The same tools work in reverse for habits you want to break.

Hide the cue. If you always check your phone first thing in the morning, don't keep it by the bed. If you always snack while studying, don't keep snacks on the desk. If a particular app always pulls you in, remove it from your home screen.

Add friction. Log out of social media after each use. Put the television remote in a drawer. Unplug the game console and put it in a cupboard. Every extra step gives you a chance to notice what you're doing.

Replace the routine. Habits meet needs. As you saw in Chapter 6, if you remove a habit without replacing it, the need remains and the habit usually returns. Keep the cue and the reward, but change the routine. Bored at your desk? Instead of opening a video, stand up and stretch. Want a break from studying? Instead of scrolling, step outside for five minutes.

Notice and name. When you catch yourself in a bad habit, simply naming it ("there's the phone habit again") creates a small gap between the cue and the routine. In that gap, you can make a different choice.

Build a starting routine

One of the most useful habits for focus is a consistent way to start your working day. Without one, many people drift into the day through email, news and messages, and by the time they reach their important work, half their best energy is gone.

A starting routine can be short. Daniel's took about ten minutes:

1. Make coffee.
2. Put phone in the drawer, switch on work focus mode.
3. Read the MIT card from the night before.
4. Open the project file. Close everything else.
5. Write the target for the first block.
6. Start a 45-minute timer.

Tariq's, for his early-morning coding sessions, was even simpler: get up, drink a glass of water, sit at the kitchen table where he'd left the laptop open the night before, start the timer.

The important thing isn't what's in the routine. It's that it's the same every day, so it becomes automatic and carries you into your work without a fight.

Identity: who you're becoming

James Clear makes a point about habits that many people find powerful: every action you take is a vote for the type of person you want to become.

Each time you sit down for a focus session, you cast a vote for being someone who focuses. Each time you put your phone away during dinner, you cast a vote for being someone who's present with their family. One vote doesn't decide anything. But as the votes add up, your sense of who you are begins to change, and so do your habits.

This is a useful way to think about bad days, too. A missed session is one vote the other way. It doesn't undo the hundred votes you've already cast. Just make sure the next vote goes the right way.

Don't try to change everything at once

There's a temptation, when you read a chapter like this, to design a perfect new life: wake at 5:30, meditate, exercise, journal, deep work, healthy lunch, no phone, read for an hour, bed at ten.

Most people who try this last a week.

Habits take time and attention to build, and you only have so much of both. Choose one or two new habits at a time. Make them small. Get them to the point where they feel automatic, which may take a couple of months. Then add another.

It feels slow. It's actually the fastest route, because the habits you build this way tend to last.

Try this today

Design one new focus habit.

1. Choose one habit that would make the biggest difference to your focus. It might be your starting routine, putting your phone away after dinner, writing tomorrow's MIT each evening, or one daily focus session.

2. Write a habit stack: “After I [existing habit], I will [new habit].”
3. Make it tiny. What’s the two-minute version?
4. Decide on an immediate reward: a tracker mark, a small celebration, or a temptation bundle.
5. Set up the environment: make the cue obvious and remove any friction.
6. Start a habit tracker. It can be a calendar on your wall, a page in your notebook, or an app. Mark today, if you do it.

Then choose one bad habit to weaken, and change one thing about its cue or friction.

Reflection

- What habits currently fill my mornings and evenings? Which help my focus, and which hurt it?
- What existing daily habit could I use as an anchor for a new one?
- What kind of person do I want my daily actions to vote for?

Chapter 17: Protect your energy

For the first few months of his course, Tariq's routine looked heroic on paper. Work from 8:30 to 5:30. Home by 6:15. Dinner. Coding from 8:00 to 11:00, sometimes midnight. Up at 6:30 for work again. Weekends: four or five hours of coding each day.

He was proud of it, and for a while it worked. Then it didn't. By the third month he was falling asleep at the kitchen table with his hands on the keyboard. He made mistakes at his day job that he'd never made before. He snapped at his kids over nothing. And his coding slowed to a crawl. He'd stare at a problem for an hour that he'd have solved in ten minutes when he was fresh.

"I thought the answer was to push harder," he said. "I was getting maybe five and a half hours of sleep a night. Then I'd drink more coffee and push harder. It took me far too long to realize I was making everything worse."

Focus runs on energy

Everything in this book depends on a basic fact: attention needs energy. When you're well rested, fed, moving and not overwhelmed by stress, focus comes much more easily. When you're exhausted, hungry, sedentary and stressed, even the best techniques struggle.

This chapter covers the foundations: sleep, movement, food, rest, and the boundaries that protect them. None of it is glamorous. All

of it matters more than any productivity app.

Sleep comes first

If you only improve one thing in this chapter, make it sleep.

Sleep affects almost every part of focus. When you're short of sleep, your attention lapses more often, your working memory holds less, you're more easily distracted, you find it harder to control impulses, and you feel worse, which makes procrastination more tempting. In the short term, coffee can hide some of this. It can't hide all of it, and it can't make up for weeks of short nights.

The American Academy of Sleep Medicine and the Sleep Research Society published a joint recommendation in 2015 that adults should regularly sleep seven hours or more a night for good health. Some people need more. Teenagers and young adults often need more still. Very few people do well on much less, even if they've told themselves for years that they're fine.

Some practical ways to improve sleep:

- **Keep a consistent schedule.** Go to bed and get up at roughly the same times every day, including weekends if you can. Your body clock works best with regularity.
- **Take the phone out of the bedroom** (Chapter 6). This alone helps many people.
- **Wind down.** Spend the last thirty to sixty minutes before bed doing something calm: reading a paper book, a warm shower, light stretching, talking, prayer or quiet reflection. Avoid work email, intense games and the news.
- **Watch the caffeine.** Caffeine stays in your body for hours. In a 2013 study by Christopher Drake and colleagues, a dose of caf-

feine taken even six hours before bed reduced people's total sleep by more than an hour. A reasonable rule for many people is no caffeine after early afternoon.

- **Keep the bedroom dark, cool and quiet.**
- **Get morning light.** Spending some time outside in daylight in the morning helps set your body clock, which makes it easier to fall asleep at night.

If you snore heavily, regularly wake up exhausted after a full night, or lie awake most nights despite good habits, talk to a doctor. Sleep problems such as sleep apnea and insomnia are common and treatable.

Move your body

Physical activity helps focus in two ways. In the short term, a burst of exercise, even a brisk walk, often leaves people feeling more alert and better able to concentrate. In the long term, regular activity supports better sleep, better mood and better health, all of which support attention.

The World Health Organization's 2020 guidelines recommend that adults do at least 150 to 300 minutes of moderate activity a week, such as brisk walking or cycling, or 75 to 150 minutes of vigorous activity, along with muscle-strengthening activities on two or more days. That sounds like a lot, but 150 minutes is just over twenty minutes a day.

You don't need a gym. Walk to the shops. Take the stairs. Go for a walk at lunch. Do ten minutes of bodyweight exercises in your living room. Use your work breaks to move (Chapter 12).

If you sit for most of the day, as most students and office workers do, it's also worth breaking up long periods of sitting, by standing up and moving around for a few minutes every half hour or so.

Food and water

You don't need a special diet to focus. But a few basic things help most people.

- **Don't skip meals and then crash.** Long gaps without food can leave you irritable and unfocused, and then you're more likely to grab something sugary that gives you a quick high and a slump.
- **Eat regular meals with some protein, fiber and vegetables.** They give steadier energy than meals made mostly of sugar and white flour.
- **Be careful with very heavy lunches** if you have important work in the afternoon. Many people find a lighter lunch helps with the afternoon dip.
- **Drink water.** Even mild dehydration can make people feel tired and less focused. Keep a bottle on your desk.
- **Notice how alcohol affects you.** Alcohol may help you fall asleep, but it tends to disrupt sleep later in the night, which can leave you foggy the next day.

Rest is not laziness

Many people who struggle with productivity feel guilty when they rest. If they're not working, they feel they should be. So they half-rest: watching television while answering emails, scrolling in bed, "relaxing" while thinking about their to-do list. They never really work, and they never really rest.

Real rest is something you do on purpose, without guilt, because you need it. It's part of the system, not a break from it.

Different kinds of rest help with different kinds of tiredness:

- Physical rest: sleep, naps, lying down, gentle stretching.
- Mental rest: activities that let your mind relax, like a walk without headphones, gardening, cooking, a hobby with your hands.
- Social rest: time with people who make you feel good, without the demands of work.
- Sensory rest: time away from screens, noise and bright lights.
- Creative or spiritual rest: music, art, nature, prayer, reflection, anything that reminds you what matters to you.

Notice which kind you need most. A person who's been in back-to-back video calls all day may need sensory and social quiet. A student who's been studying alone for hours may need social time and movement.

The shutdown ritual

One of the most important boundaries for focus is a clear end to the workday. Without one, work leaks into the evening. You check email "just once" after dinner. You lie in bed thinking about tomorrow's tasks. You never fully switch off, so you never fully recover.

Cal Newport describes a shutdown ritual: a short, fixed routine at the end of each workday that closes everything down. A version you can adapt:

1. **Check your inbox and messages one last time**, and capture anything that needs doing.

2. **Look at your task list and calendar for tomorrow.**
3. **Choose tomorrow's MIT** and write it down (Chapter 9).
4. **Leave a note** on any unfinished task about where you stopped and what comes next (Chapter 8).
5. **Tidy your desk** so it's ready for tomorrow.
6. **Say a phrase** that marks the end. Newport uses "shutdown complete". You might prefer "done for today". The phrase is a signal to your mind that work is finished.
7. **Close the laptop**, switch off work notifications, and leave your workspace.

The whole ritual takes ten to fifteen minutes. It means that when a work thought pops up in the evening, you can tell yourself honestly: *I've already dealt with that. It's on the list for tomorrow.*

For people who work from home, like Daniel, the shutdown ritual is especially important, because there's no commute to mark the change. Daniel started ending each day with a ten-minute walk around the block, which became his "commute home". When he came back, work was over.

Boundaries

Energy is also protected by boundaries: limits on how much of your time and attention others can take.

Some useful boundaries:

- **Work hours.** A clear start and end time, which you keep to on most days.
- **Response times.** Agreed expectations about how quickly you'll reply to messages outside work hours (often: not until the next working day).

- **Notification-free time.** Evenings, weekends or certain hours when work notifications are switched off.
- **Protected time.** Your deep work blocks, your exercise, your family dinners, your day off.
- **A real day off.** At least one day a week, if at all possible, with no work and no study. Many faiths and cultures build this into the week for good reason.

Boundaries can be hard to set, especially at the start of a job or when you're working for yourself. But without them, the most demanding person or task always wins, and your energy drains away without your noticing.

Watch for burnout

Sometimes tiredness is more than tiredness.

In 2019, the World Health Organization included burnout in its International Classification of Diseases as an "occupational phenomenon", not a medical condition, caused by chronic workplace stress that hasn't been successfully managed. It describes three features: feelings of exhaustion or energy depletion; increased mental distance from your job, or feelings of negativity or cynicism about it; and a sense of reduced effectiveness at work.

Similar patterns can show up in students, carers and people working on demanding personal projects. Warning signs include:

- Feeling exhausted most of the time, even after rest.
- Dreading work or study that you used to care about.
- Becoming cynical, irritable or detached.
- Feeling that nothing you do makes a difference.
- Trouble sleeping, frequent headaches or illness.

If you recognize these in yourself, more productivity techniques are not the answer. You need to reduce the load, increase recovery, and possibly talk to someone: a doctor, a counselor, a manager, a trusted friend. Burnout is a sign that something in your situation needs to change, not a sign that you're weak.

What Tariq changed

When Tariq finally admitted his routine wasn't working, he made three changes.

He moved two of his coding sessions to early mornings, after discovering (Chapter 13) that his energy was much higher then. To make that possible, he went to bed by 10:30 on weekdays.

He cut his evening coding to a maximum of one hour, ending by 9:30, followed by a wind-down without screens.

He took Sundays off completely. No code, no tutorials, no "just checking" the course forums. Time with his family, a long walk, and an evening with a book.

His total coding hours dropped by about a third. His progress sped up. "I'd been working three tired hours a night and getting about one hour's worth of progress," he said. "Now I work fewer hours and actually get them."

Try this today

Do an energy check.

1. For the past week, estimate how many hours you slept each night. Write down the average.
2. Write down how much physical activity you did in the past week, in total minutes.

3. Note when you last had a full day with no work or study.
4. Choose one change for this week in each of two areas: sleep (for example, a consistent bedtime, no caffeine after 2 p.m., phone out of the bedroom) and movement (for example, a twenty-minute walk every day).
5. Design your shutdown ritual. Write down the steps you'll do at the end of each workday, and the phrase you'll use to mark the end.

Tonight, do your shutdown ritual for the first time.

Reflection

- When do I feel most energetic, and what's different about those days?
- What am I trying to make up for with caffeine, late nights or pushing harder?
- What boundary do I most need to set, and who do I need to tell?

Part Five: Focus in real life

Lectures and exams, inboxes and clients, children and side projects. These three chapters put the whole system to work in the places where life actually happens.

Chapter 18: Focus for students

For most of her first year, Sana studied the way almost everyone around her studied. She read her lecture notes. She reread them. She highlighted the important parts in yellow, then the really important parts in pink. The night before an exam, she read everything one more time, and it all looked familiar.

Then she sat down in the exam hall, turned over the paper, and found she couldn't answer half the questions. She recognized the topics. She just couldn't pull the details out of her head.

"I'd spent hours on it," she said. "I really thought I knew it. It was like the information was in there somewhere, but I couldn't reach it."

She'd done what millions of students do: confused familiarity with knowledge. And she'd spent many of her focused hours on study methods that feel productive but don't work very well.

This chapter applies the whole focus system to studying. But first, it's worth making sure your focused hours go into methods that work.

Methods that work, and methods that feel like they work

In 2013, John Dunlosky and four colleagues published a long review of ten popular study techniques, looking at the evidence for

each across many studies, ages and subjects. They rated each technique as high, moderate or low in usefulness.

Two techniques came out on top.

Practice testing. Testing yourself on the material, through flashcards, practice questions, past papers, or simply closing the book and trying to write down what you remember. This is sometimes called retrieval practice, because you're practicing pulling information out of your memory, which is exactly what an exam asks you to do.

Distributed practice. Spreading your study of a topic over several sessions, with gaps between them, instead of doing it all in one go. This is often called spacing.

Several popular techniques came out low, including highlighting, rereading and summarizing (as many students do it). These aren't useless, but they produce much less learning for the time they take. They also feel effective, because the material starts to look familiar. That familiarity is exactly the trap Sana fell into.

Why testing beats rereading

In a 2006 study, Henry Roediger and Jeffrey Karpicke gave students short passages to learn. Some students studied the passage several times. Others studied it once and then took practice tests in which they tried to recall what they'd read. When tested five minutes later, the students who'd restudied did slightly better. But when tested a week later, the students who'd practiced recall remembered much more.

Rereading makes material feel easy, which is satisfying in the moment. Testing yourself is harder and often frustrating, because you

discover what you don't know. But that difficulty is a sign of learning. Each time you pull something out of memory, you make it easier to pull out next time.

For focus, this has a useful side effect. Practice testing is active. It gives your attention a clear job, which makes it much harder to drift than passive reading.

Spacing: little and often

The second high-value technique, spacing, fits perfectly with the focus sessions you learned in Part Three.

Instead of studying one topic for six hours on one day, study it for an hour on six different days, spread over a couple of weeks. You'll remember more, for longer. In 2006, Nicholas Cepeda and colleagues combined the results of hundreds of experiments on spacing and found that spreading study sessions out consistently produced better long-term retention than cramming the same amount of study into one block.

This is also why cramming doesn't work well. It may get you through tomorrow's test, but much of what you crammed is gone within days, and you have to learn it all again for the final exam.

A study session that works

Put the two techniques together with your focus skills, and a good study session looks like this:

1. **Set a target.** "Pharmacology: anticoagulants. Answer the 15 practice questions at the end of the chapter, then make flashcards for anything I got wrong."

2. **Protect the session.** Phone in another room, unnecessary tabs closed, timer set (Chapters 6, 7 and 12).
3. **Start with retrieval.** Before you look at your notes, spend five minutes writing down everything you remember about the topic. It's a quick warm-up that tells you where the gaps are.
4. **Study actively.** Read or review a section, then close the book and explain it in your own words, out loud or in writing. Ask yourself why and how questions: *Why does this drug interact with that one? How would this change if the patient had kidney problems?*
5. **Test yourself.** Practice questions, past papers, flashcards.
6. **Check and correct.** Look up what you got wrong and make sure you understand it.
7. **Schedule the next review.** Put this topic back in your plan in a few days, and again in a week or two.

The Feynman technique

The physicist Richard Feynman was famous for his ability to explain complicated ideas simply. A study method based on his approach is now widely used, and it's another form of active recall.

1. Choose a concept you're learning.
2. Explain it, on paper or out loud, as if you were teaching it to a twelve-year-old. Use simple words. Avoid jargon.
3. When you get stuck or find yourself waving your hands, that's a gap in your understanding. Go back to your notes and fill it.
4. Simplify your explanation again.

If you can explain something simply, you understand it. If you can't, you've found exactly what to study next.

Planning for exams

Use the planning tools from Part Three, working backward from the exam date.

1. **List every topic** that might be examined.
2. **Rate each topic** by how well you know it now (1 to 5) and how important it is in the exam.
3. **Count the study sessions you realistically have** between now and the exam, using your normal weekly schedule, with buffer days (Chapter 10).
4. **Allocate sessions to topics**, giving more to weak, important topics. Make sure every topic gets at least two or three sessions spread over time, not one big block.
5. **Leave the last few days for mixed practice**: past papers and practice questions from all topics together, under timed conditions.
6. **Protect your sleep.** Especially in the last week. Pulling all-nighters before exams usually hurts more than it helps, because sleep is when much of the day's learning gets consolidated in memory.

Lectures and online classes

Lectures are a classic place for attention to wander, whether you're in a hall or watching on a screen.

A few things help:

- **Close everything except your notes.** In a 2013 study, Faria Sana, Tina Weston and Nicholas Cepeda found that students who multitasked on laptops during a lecture understood less of it. So did students sitting nearby who could see the multi-

taskers' screens. If you take notes on a laptop, use full-screen mode with nothing else open.

- **Consider handwritten notes**, at least for some classes. Many students find that writing by hand forces them to summarize and think, instead of transcribing.
- **Prepare questions in advance.** Skim the reading or slides before the lecture and write down two or three questions you want answered. You'll listen differently.
- **For recorded lectures**, resist the urge to have them on in the background while doing something else. Watch them like a live class, with notes, and pause to test yourself.

Long assignments

Essays, dissertations and big projects are where procrastination does its worst damage, because the deadline is far away and the task is large and vague.

Use everything from Chapters 9 to 11:

- **Break it down** into small steps (choose topic, find sources, outline, draft section 1, and so on).
- **Set your own deadlines** for each step, spaced out, and tell someone about them (Chapter 14).
- **Schedule the first step** for this week, not "when I have time".
- **Write an ugly first draft** quickly, then improve it.
- **Stop in the middle** each day so tomorrow's start is easy.

Studying with others

Group study can help or hurt focus, depending on how it's run. It helps when it's active and structured: quizzing each other, ex-

plaining concepts in turn, working through problems together. It hurts when it's mostly chatting with books open.

If you study with friends, agree in advance on what you'll cover and for how long. Use focus sessions together: everyone works in silence for 25 or 50 minutes, then you discuss or test each other during the break. Many students also find "body doubling", working silently alongside someone else, in person or on a video call, makes it easier to stay on task.

Sana's exam season

For her second-year exams, Sana built a plan on these principles. She listed her topics and rated them. She planned two or three fifty-minute study sessions a day, with Sunday afternoons as buffer. Each session started with five minutes of writing down what she remembered, then active study, then practice questions. Each topic came back at least three times over the six weeks. The last week was past papers.

She stopped highlighting. She still reread her notes sometimes, but only after she'd tested herself.

"It was harder," she said. "Testing myself was horrible at first, because I kept finding out how much I didn't know. Rereading felt so much nicer. But in the exam, I could actually remember things. That had never happened before."

Her marks went up in every module. More than that, she studied fewer hours than the year before, and she slept every night of exam season.

Try this today

Upgrade one study session.

1. Choose one topic you need to learn or revise.
2. Before you look at any notes, spend five minutes writing down everything you remember about it.
3. Compare with your notes. Mark the gaps.
4. Spend 25 minutes studying the gaps actively: explain each one in your own words, or use the Feynman technique.
5. Test yourself with practice questions or flashcards for 10 minutes.
6. Put two more review sessions for this topic in your calendar: one in three days, one in about a week.

Reflection

- Which study methods do I rely on most, and are they high-value or low-value?
- Where do I most often confuse “this looks familiar” with “I know this”?
- What’s my next big assignment or exam, and what’s the first small step I can schedule this week?

Chapter 19: Focus at work, in business and at home

Each of the four people in this book faces a different kind of pressure on their attention. Sana has lectures, exams and a phone full of friends. Daniel has a manager, a team, an inbox and a calendar that other people can write in. Amira has clients, customers and a business that depends partly on the same social media that distracts her. Tariq has a full-time job, two teenagers, a household and a dream that has to fit into what's left.

The principles are the same for all of them: find what matters, organize time for it, control distractions, use energy wisely and sustain progress. But the details differ. This chapter looks at how the system works in three settings: the workplace, running your own business, and home life with family.

At work: when other people own your calendar

Daniel's biggest problem wasn't his phone. It was other people. His calendar was visible to his whole team, so anyone could book a meeting into any empty slot. His chat was expected to be open all day. His manager sent messages at all hours and seemed to expect fast replies.

If your job is like this, you can't simply switch everything off. But you usually have more room than you think.

Block your calendar first

The simplest defense is to fill your calendar before others do. At the start of each week, block your deep work time (Chapter 8) as if it were a meeting. Give it a clear, professional name, like “Project planning: do not book” or “Focus time”. Most colleagues will book around it.

Daniel blocked 8:00 to 9:30 every weekday and two afternoons a week from 2:00 to 3:30. A few people booked over the blocks anyway at first. He politely suggested other times, and after a few weeks the blocks were mostly respected.

Make meetings earn their place

Meetings are often the biggest drain on focus at work, because they break the day into fragments too short for serious work.

Before accepting a meeting, ask:

- **Is there a clear purpose or agenda?** If not, ask for one. “Happy to join. Could you send a quick agenda so I can prepare?” Often this is enough to make the meeting better, or to reveal that it isn’t needed.
- **Do I need to be there?** Could someone else attend, or could you read the notes afterward?
- **Could it be shorter?** Many meetings are scheduled for an hour because that’s the calendar’s default. Try 25 or 45 minutes.
- **Could it be an email or a message instead?**

When you do run meetings, end them with clear decisions and actions: who’s doing what, by when. A meeting that ends without decisions usually leads to another meeting.

It also helps to cluster meetings together. Two meetings back to back in the afternoon leave the morning free for deep work. The same two meetings at 10:00 and 2:00 break the whole day.

Agree on what's urgent

Much of the pressure to reply instantly comes from unspoken assumptions. Have the conversation out loud.

Daniel asked his manager for fifteen minutes and said something like this: "I want to make sure I'm getting the project plan and the big pieces done, not just reacting to messages all day. I'd like to block two focus periods a day when I'm not checking chat. If something's really urgent, could you call me? Otherwise I'll reply within a couple of hours."

His manager agreed, and was actually relieved. She'd been worried about the project plan too.

Not every manager will respond so well. But many will, especially if you frame the request around getting important work done, and especially if you then deliver.

Handle interruptions in person

In an office, interruptions often come from colleagues stopping by. A few strategies:

- **Use a visible signal.** Headphones on, or a small sign, means you're focusing.
- **Offer a later time.** "I'm in the middle of something. Can I come and find you at 11?"
- **Hold office hours.** If people often need your help, set regular times when you're available for questions, and encourage them to save non-urgent questions for those times.

- **Find a hiding place.** If your office has quiet rooms or a library, use them for deep work.

When your job is reactive

Some jobs, such as customer service, IT support, healthcare, retail and reception, are reactive by nature. You can't schedule hours of uninterrupted focus, because responding is the job.

In these roles, the system adapts. Focus on doing one thing at a time, fully, instead of juggling several. Use quieter moments for small chunks of planned work, with notes so you can resume quickly (Chapter 8). Protect your attention outside work even more carefully, so you arrive each day rested. And if you have any important non-reactive work, such as a project or a qualification, try to schedule it before or after the reactive part of your day, or on a quieter day.

In business: when you're the boss

Amira had a different problem. Nobody told her what to do. That was the appeal of working for herself, and also the danger. Without a manager, a schedule or colleagues, every day was hers to plan, and every day she could choose not to.

If you run your own business or work freelance, a few extra principles help.

Give yourself a boss

Self-employed people need structure even more than employees, because nobody else is providing it. Create the structure deliberately:

- **Set working hours**, and keep to them on most days. Start and finish at roughly the same time.

- **Hold a weekly planning meeting with yourself** (Chapter 20), as seriously as you'd attend one with a client.
- **Find accountability.** A business friend you check in with weekly. A co-working space. A coach or mentor. An online group of other freelancers.

Separate working on the business from working in it

Most small business owners spend almost all their time working *in* the business: doing the work clients pay for, answering messages, packing orders, handling problems. Very little time goes to working *on* the business: improving prices, finding better clients, building systems, planning for the future.

The second kind of work is almost always important and not urgent (Chapter 9), which means it gets pushed aside. Give it a fixed block every week. Amira chose Friday mornings: no client work, no messages, just thinking about the business. In that block, she raised her prices, built her proposal template, and planned how to find more brand clients. It was the most valuable time in her week.

Use social media without being used by it

For many business owners, social media is both a necessary tool and a constant distraction. The trick is to separate creating and publishing from consuming.

- **Batch your content.** Create several posts in one session, then schedule them to publish automatically.
- **Reply in windows.** Check comments and messages at set times, not continuously.
- **Use a computer, not your phone**, for business social media where possible. It's easier to do what you came to do and leave.

- **Unfollow accounts that drain you**, especially competitors whose highlight reels make you anxious.
- **Measure what matters.** Track whether social media actually brings customers. Amira discovered that her daily posts brought in very few sales, while three strong posts a week did almost as well. That freed hours.

Set boundaries with clients

Clients will often take as much of your time and attention as you give them. Clear boundaries protect both your focus and the quality of your work.

- **State your response times** in your contracts, your email signature or an automatic reply.
- **Define the scope of each project** in writing, and agree in advance how changes will be handled and charged.
- **Don't answer business messages late at night** unless you've agreed to and are being paid for it.
- **Batch client calls** on particular days or afternoons, where possible.

When Amira introduced her twice-a-day reply schedule, she worried she'd lose clients. She didn't lose any. Two told her it made her seem more professional.

At home: focus with family

Tariq's challenge was the one many people with families face. His time wasn't really his own. Work took the day. Family took the evening, and rightly so. His goal had to fit into the cracks.

Find your real hours

The first step is honesty about how much time you actually have. Look at a typical week and mark the hours that are truly available for focused work on your goal, after work, sleep, meals, family and essential household tasks.

For many parents and carers, the honest answer is small: perhaps five to ten hours a week, often in early mornings, late evenings, nap times or weekends. That can feel discouraging. But five focused hours a week is 260 hours a year, enough to learn a lot, build a lot, or finish a major project. The key is to use those hours well, not to pretend you have more.

Make agreements, not demands

You met Tariq's family agreement in Chapter 7. The principles are worth repeating, because they apply to almost every household:

- Explain what you're doing and why it matters.
- Ask for specific, limited times.
- Agree on a signal and on what counts as urgent.
- Keep your side of the deal by being fully present outside those times.

With a partner, it often helps to trade focus time. One adult takes the children for an hour on Saturday morning while the other works, then they swap.

Work in short bursts

If you can't get long blocks, make the most of short ones. Twenty-five minutes during a nap. Forty minutes before the house wakes up. Fifteen minutes on the train. With a clear target, a ready-to-re-

sume note from last time (Chapter 8) and your phone away, a short session can achieve far more than you'd expect.

The two-minute start and the minimum version (Chapter 11) are especially useful here. On days when there's no time at all, do the minimum. Keep the chain going.

Be present when you're present

Focus at home isn't only about your own goals. It's also about the quality of your attention for the people you live with.

Children notice when a parent's eyes keep going to a phone. Partners notice when conversations are half-heard. The same skills that protect your work, single-tasking, putting the phone away, being fully where you are, also protect your relationships.

Tariq made a rule that dinner was phone-free for everyone, including him. At first his teenagers complained. After a few weeks, dinners got longer. "We actually talk now," he said. "My daughter told me about a problem at school that she'd never have mentioned if we'd all been on our phones. That's worth more than any amount of coding."

Seasons of life

Finally, it's worth accepting that focus looks different at different times of life. A parent with a newborn, a person caring for a sick relative, someone going through grief or illness, a student in exam season, an employee in a crisis at work: each of these is a season with its own limits.

In a demanding season, lower your expectations without abandoning your goals. Shrink your process goals. Focus on the minimum. Protect sleep. Ask for help. The season will pass, and when it

does, the habits you've kept alive, even in their smallest form, will be ready to grow again.

Try this today

Choose the section of this chapter that fits your life best, and take one action from it.

- **At work:** block two focus periods in your calendar for next week, and decline or shorten one meeting.
- **In business:** schedule a weekly block for working on your business, and set a response-time policy for client or customer messages.
- **At home:** list your real available hours for a typical week, and have a conversation with your family about one protected focus time.

Then choose one place in your life where you'll practice being fully present, such as dinner, the walk to school or a weekly call with a parent, and keep your phone away for it.

Reflection

- Who or what has the most control over my time, and how much of that control is real?
- What's one conversation I need to have to protect my focus?
- What season of life am I in, and what does a realistic level of progress look like right now?

Chapter 20: Your focus system for life

By now you have a lot of tools. Focus sessions and the focus ladder. A digital reset. A workspace designed for work. Deep work blocks and batched shallow work. The urgent-important matrix and the MIT. Time blocking with buffers. Two-minute starts and if-then plans. Work rhythms and real breaks. Templates and checklists. Process goals and WOOP. Self-compassion and the reset routine. Habit stacks and trackers. Sleep, movement and a shutdown ritual.

You don't need to use all of them all the time. Nobody does. What you need is a simple, repeatable way to keep the system working, notice when it isn't, and fix it without starting over every time.

That's what this chapter is for. It brings everything together into a rhythm of daily, weekly and monthly routines that you can keep for years.

The daily rhythm

Your daily routine should be short enough to survive a bad day. For most people, it has three parts.

The start (5 to 10 minutes). Your starting routine from Chapter 16: phone to its home, focus mode on, read your MIT, set the target for your first session, start the timer.

The work (your sessions). One to three focused sessions on important work, at your best-energy times. Shallow work batched

into one or two windows. Real breaks.

The shutdown (10 to 15 minutes). Your shutdown ritual from Chapter 17: capture loose ends, look at tomorrow, choose tomorrow's MIT, leave a note on unfinished work, tidy up, mark the end.

That's the core. On a good day you'll do more. On a bad day, do the minimum: choose an MIT, do one session (even a short one), and shut down properly.

The weekly review

The weekly review is the single most important routine for keeping your system alive. It's where you step back from the daily rush, look at the bigger picture and adjust.

Choose a fixed time each week, and give it thirty to forty-five minutes. Many people use Friday afternoon (to close the week) or Sunday evening (to prepare for the next). Put it in your calendar as a recurring appointment.

Here's a structure you can follow. Use the weekly review page in the toolkit at the back of this book if it helps.

1. Clear (10 minutes).

- Empty your capture list, inbox and notes into one place. Decide what to do with each item: do, schedule, delegate or delete.
- Clear your desk and your computer desktop.
- Close any open loops: replies you owe, small tasks you forgot.

2. Review (10 minutes).

- Look back at the past week's calendar. What happened? What got done?

- Look at your lead measures (Chapter 14). How many focus sessions did you complete? Did you keep your key habits?
- Look at your screen time numbers. Up or down?
- Ask three questions and write short answers:
  - *What went well this week?*
  - *What got in the way?*
  - *What will I do differently next week?*

3. Plan (15 minutes).

- Look at your goals and milestones. Are you on track?
- Choose your big rocks for next week: the one to three most important outcomes.
- Look at next week's calendar. Block time for your big rocks, your deep work and your breaks. Add buffer.
- Note any obstacles you can see coming, and make an if-then plan for each.

4. Close (2 minutes).

- Choose Monday's MIT.
- Say your shutdown phrase. The week is done.

The first few weekly reviews may feel slow and awkward. After a month, most people find it's the half hour that makes the rest of the week work. Daniel described his Friday review as "the meeting that makes all the other meetings bearable".

The FOCUS check

When something isn't working, use the FOCUS method from the start of the book to find out where the problem is. During your weekly review, ask one question for each letter.

F: Find. *Do I know what matters most right now?* If you're busy but not making progress, or you feel scattered, go back to Chapter 9. Re-sort your list, choose your big rocks, write your MIT.

O: Organize. *Does my important work have a place in my calendar?* If important tasks keep getting pushed aside, or your plans keep collapsing, go back to Chapter 10. Block time, add buffer, use the 50 percent rule.

C: Control. *Am I protecting my attention from distraction?* If you're losing time to your phone, interruptions or a cluttered environment, go back to Chapters 6 and 7. Check your notifications, your phone's home, your workspace, your agreements with others.

U: Use. *Am I working with my energy?* If you're tired, slow or burnt out, go back to Chapters 12, 13 and 17. Check your sleep, your breaks, your best hours, your boundaries.

S: Sustain. *Are my habits holding?* If you start well and fade, or keep abandoning your routines after a slip, go back to Chapters 15 and 16. Shrink your habits, use the reset routine, track your progress, never miss twice.

Most weeks, one letter will stand out. Fix that one. Don't try to fix everything.

The monthly reset

Once a month, spend an hour on a deeper review. A good time is the first weekend of the month, which also takes advantage of the fresh start effect (Chapter 15).

In the monthly reset:

- **Review your goals.** Are they still the right ones? Has anything changed in your life that means they need adjusting? Is there a

goal you should drop or move to the "later" list?

- **Review your milestones.** Did you reach this month's? If not, why not? Adjust the timeline if needed. Being realistic is not the same as giving up.
- **Review your habits.** Which ones are now automatic? Which are still a struggle? Is it time to add a new one?
- **Review your digital life.** Check your screen time trends. Look at your notifications again. Have any apps crept back onto your home screen? Has a new app become a problem?
- **Review your commitments.** Is there anything you've agreed to that you should now step back from?
- **Choose one experiment for next month.** One new technique to try, one habit to build, or one change to make. Write it down.

When things fall apart

At some point, probably more than once, your system will collapse. A family crisis, a new job, illness, a move, a new baby, a breakup, a long holiday, or simply a slow slide over several weeks. You'll look up one day and realize you haven't done a focus session in a month, your phone time has doubled, and your weekly review is a distant memory.

This is normal. It happens to everyone who tries to build a system like this. The question isn't whether it'll happen, but how you'll respond.

Here's how to rebuild:

1. **Don't try to restart everything at once.** That's the all-or-nothing trap again (Chapter 15).

2. **Use the reset routine.** Name what happened, be kind, look for causes, decide what to change.
3. **Start with the smallest core.** One MIT a day and one short focus session. That's all, for the first week.
4. **Add the weekly review back** in the second week.
5. **Add other pieces gradually**, one per week, in the order that matters most for you: often the digital reset first, then the workspace, then the habits.
6. **Choose a fresh start date** if it helps, and tell someone.

Most people find that rebuilding is much faster than building the first time. The habits haven't disappeared. They're just dormant, and they wake up quickly.

A year from now

Imagine yourself a year from today.

Imagine that, for most of that year, you've done one or two focused sessions on your most important goal on most days. You've kept your phone out of your bedroom. You've done a weekly review most weeks. You've slept reasonably well, moved a bit every day, and had a real day off each week. You've had bad weeks, and you've recovered from them.

What would be different?

Here's roughly where the four people in this book got to, a year after they began.

Sana finished her second year with the best marks she'd ever had, and started her third year with a study routine she no longer had to think about. Her screen time settled at a little over two hours a day, most of it messages and music. She still loves short videos. She

watches them on her laptop on Saturday evenings, and stops when the evening ends.

Daniel delivered his project on time, and his director asked him to lead the next one. He still works from his bedroom corner, but behind a folding screen, with a clean desk and a ten-minute walk to end each day. He's home for dinner most nights. "I'm doing less," he said, "but what I do actually matters now."

Amira raised her prices twice, works with fewer, better clients, and takes Fridays off from client work to think about her business. She still struggles with perfectionism. She just has a timer now, and a rule: "good" is good enough for almost everything.

Tariq finished his course, built three small apps, and, after eleven applications and two disappointing interviews, accepted a junior developer role at a company that builds software for accountants, where his old career turned out to be an advantage. He codes in the mornings, takes Sundays off and still eats dinner with his phone in the hallway basket.

None of them became different people. None of them achieved perfect focus. They all still have distracted days, lost evenings and weeks where the system wobbles. What changed was that focused, meaningful work became a normal part of their lives, instead of something that happened only under the pressure of a deadline.

That's what's possible for you, too.

Try this today

Schedule your rhythm.

1. Put a recurring weekly review in your calendar, at a time you're likely to keep, for 30 to 45 minutes.

2. Put a recurring monthly reset in your calendar, on the first weekend of each month, for one hour.
3. Write down your daily minimum: the smallest version of your start, your work and your shutdown that you'll do even on a bad day.
4. Do a quick FOCUS check now. Which letter needs the most attention this week? Write down one action for it.

Reflection

- Which part of the system has helped me most so far?
- Which part do I keep dropping, and how could I make it smaller or easier?
- What do I want my focus to make possible a year from now?

Closing: the next ordinary day

This book began with Sana at 9:40 on a Tuesday night, notes open, phone buzzing, and an evening about to disappear. It's worth ending with an ordinary Tuesday too, because that's where everything in this book is really decided.

Not on the day you read a chapter and feel inspired. Not on the first of January, or the first day of a new job, or the morning after a wake-up call. Those days matter, but they're rare. Most of your life will be spent on ordinary days: slightly tired, a bit busy, with a to-do list longer than the time available and a phone that would very much like your attention.

On those days, you won't feel like a person with a superpower. You'll feel like yourself.

That's fine. Focus was never meant to be a feeling. It's a set of small choices, made again and again, mostly without fanfare. Putting the phone in the hallway basket. Writing tomorrow's most important task on a card. Opening the document before the email. Setting a timer for twenty-five minutes and staying with the hard paragraph when you'd rather leave. Taking a walk instead of a scroll. Forgiving yourself for yesterday and starting again today.

None of those choices is impressive on its own. Together, repeated across hundreds of ordinary days, they're how degrees get finished, businesses get built, careers get changed, books get written and families get your full attention at dinner.

You don't need to control every minute of your life. You need to take control of the moments that matter, and protect them well enough that they add up.

Here's a last suggestion. Before you close this book, pick one thing from it. Just one. The phone out of the bedroom. A daily MIT. A single focus session tomorrow morning. A weekly review on Friday. Something small enough that you'll actually do it.

Then do it tomorrow. And the day after.

When you're ready, add another.

If you'd like a structured way to do that, the 30-day challenge on the next pages will take you through the most useful practices in this book, one day at a time.

Your attention is the most valuable thing you own. It decides what you learn, what you build, who you become, and whom you love well. Spend it on purpose.

Start today.

The 30-day focus challenge

This challenge turns the main ideas in this book into one small action a day, for thirty days. Most days take between ten and forty minutes. Each one tells you which chapter to read if you want more detail.

A few guidelines before you start:

- **Do it in order.** The days build on each other. Week one is about noticing, week two about your environment and attention, week three about time and starting, and week four about habits and keeping going.
- **Keep a notebook.** Each day ends with the same four questions, and writing down your answers is part of the challenge.
- **Don't aim for perfect.** If you miss a day, do it the next day and carry on. Never miss twice (Chapter 15). If a whole week goes badly, repeat that week.
- **Adapt freely.** If a day's task doesn't fit your life, change it to something that does. The point is the practice, not the exact instructions.
- **Start on a fresh-start day** if you like, such as a Monday or the first of a month.

The daily check-in

At the end of each day, write short answers to four questions:

1. What did I try today?
2. What distracted me or got in the way?
3. What worked?
4. What will I adjust tomorrow?

It takes two or three minutes. Over thirty days, these notes become a detailed record of how your attention works.

Week 1: Awareness

This week you're not trying to change much. You're gathering evidence about how your attention, time and energy actually behave.

Day 1: Track your distractions. Carry a small notebook or a note on your phone. Every time you notice yourself drifting from what you meant to do, make a quick note: the time, what you switched to, and what you were feeling just before. Don't judge. Just record. (Chapter 1)

Day 2: Check your screen time. Do the screen-time audit from Chapter 3. Write down your daily average, pickups and notifications, and your top five apps. Circle the app that costs you most for what it gives. For the rest of the day, say the reason each time you pick up your phone. (Chapter 3)

Day 3: Identify your procrastination triggers. Start the procrastination log from Chapter 2. For each thing you put off today, note the task, what you did instead, the feeling, and which of the seven triggers it hits. (Chapter 2)

Day 4: Choose your most important goal. Write down the one goal you most want to make progress on in the next three months. Write a sentence about why it matters to you. Then write the very next physical action you could take toward it. (Chapters 11 and 14)

Day 5: Try one 25-minute focus session. Do the first focus experiment from Chapter 1: one task, a clear target, phone in another room, unneeded tabs closed, a 25-minute timer and a parking page. Afterward, answer the four experiment questions. (Chapters 1 and 5)

Day 6: Remove unnecessary notifications. Go through every app's notification settings and turn off everything that fails the test: "Does a human being need me, right now, through this app?" (Chapter 6)

Day 7: Review your baseline. Read back through your notes from the week. Answer: What are my three biggest distractions? When is my focus best and worst? What feeling most often comes before procrastination? Write a short paragraph describing your starting point. (Chapter 20)

Week 2: Environment and attention

This week you start reshaping the conditions around your work, and training your attention directly.

Day 8: Create a dedicated focus space. Clear your desk or work area completely, then put back only what you need for focused work. Turn your seat away from distractions if you can. Close unneeded tabs and turn off desktop notifications. If you share your space, write down the agreement you'd like to suggest. (Chapter 7)

Day 9: Set a social media boundary. Choose one specific rule. For example: no social media before noon; checking windows at lunch and 6 p.m. only; the app you circled on Day 2 deleted from your phone; or grayscale on. Write the rule down and keep it today. (Chapter 6)

Day 10: Practice single-tasking. Choose three everyday activities and do each with no other input: one meal without a screen, one conversation with your phone out of sight, one walk without headphones. At work or study, do one task at a time, fully, until it's finished or your session ends. (Chapter 8)

Day 11: Do two focus sessions. Use your starting session length from Chapter 5 (or 25 minutes). Do two sessions with a real, screen-free break between them. Log both. (Chapters 5 and 12)

Day 12: Create an if-then plan for distraction. Look at your distraction notes from Day 1. Choose your most common distraction and write an if-then plan for it: "If [situation], then I will [action]." Write two more for your next most common distractions. Use them today. (Chapter 11)

Day 13: Try a phone-free period. Choose a block of at least two hours, such as an evening or a morning, and leave your phone in another room, switched to sleep mode, for the whole time. Notice how often you reach for it and how you feel. Tonight, charge it outside your bedroom. (Chapter 6)

Day 14: Review what worked. Read back through week two's notes. Which changes made the biggest difference? Which were hardest? Choose the two or three you'll keep going forward. Check your screen time and compare it with Day 2. (Chapter 20)

Week 3: Time and execution

This week is about choosing what matters, planning realistic days and getting started on hard things.

Day 15: Identify your most important task. Write a full list of everything you need to do this week. Sort it with the urgent-im-

portant matrix. Cross out or delegate what you can. Choose up to three big rocks for the week, and tomorrow's MIT. (Chapter 9)

Day 16: Create a time-blocked schedule. Plan tomorrow using the ten-minute routine from Chapter 10: fixed commitments, MIT in your best-energy slot, one or two other important blocks, batched shallow work, breaks and at least one buffer. Add 50 percent to every estimate. (Chapter 10)

Day 17: Break down an avoided project. Choose a project you've been avoiding. Spend fifteen minutes breaking it into steps, each small enough for one session. Put them in order. Schedule the first step this week. (Chapter 11)

Day 18: Practice a two-minute start. Take the first step from yesterday's list. Set a timer for two minutes and do only that. When the timer ends, decide whether to carry on for ten minutes. (Chapter 11)

Day 19: Reduce unnecessary commitments. List your regular tasks and commitments. For each, ask: Can I eliminate it? Reduce it? Hand it over? Simplify it? Act on at least one today, even if it's just sending a message to step back from something. Start a not-to-do list. (Chapters 9 and 13)

Day 20: Try a longer focus session. Move up one rung on the focus ladder. If you've been doing 25 minutes, try 40 or 50. Prepare carefully: clear target, phone away, everything closed, water ready. Take a full 10-minute break afterward. (Chapters 5 and 12)

Day 21: Review progress and adjust. Do your first full weekly review, using the structure in Chapter 20 and the page in the toolkit: clear, review, plan, close. Do a FOCUS check and choose the letter that needs the most attention next week. (Chapter 20)

Week 4: Sustainable habits

This week is about making the changes last, and protecting the energy that makes focus possible.

Day 22: Build a morning starting routine. Design a starting routine of five to ten minutes that leads straight into your first focus session. Write it as a habit stack: "After I [existing habit], I will [first step]." Do it tomorrow morning, and track it. (Chapter 16)

Day 23: Define a realistic evening shutdown. Design your shutdown ritual: capture loose ends, look at tomorrow, choose tomorrow's MIT, leave notes on unfinished work, tidy up, say your shutdown phrase. Do it tonight. (Chapter 17)

Day 24: Create a weekly review. Put a recurring weekly review in your calendar, and a monthly reset on the first weekend of each month. Copy the weekly review page from the toolkit into your notebook, or print it. (Chapter 20)

Day 25: Practice recovering from a setback. Think of a recent time you fell short. Write down what you said to yourself. Then write what you'd say to a friend in the same situation. Do the six-step reset routine. Write a "never miss twice" plan for your most important habit. (Chapter 15)

Day 26: Protect time for rest. Look at your sleep, movement and rest from the past week. Choose one change for sleep and one for movement, and start both today. Plan a real day off, with no work or study, in the next seven days. (Chapter 17)

Day 27: Complete one meaningful milestone. Choose a small but real piece of progress on your most important goal, something you can finish today in one to three focus sessions. Finish it. Then celebrate in some small way. (Chapter 14)

Day 28: Assess your new habits. Look at your habit tracker and your notes. Which new habits feel close to automatic? Which still take effort? Which have you dropped? For each one you want to keep, decide whether to shrink it, keep it the same or grow it. (Chapter 16)

The final two days

Day 29: Design your personal FOCUS system. On one page, write down the system you'll keep using after the challenge. Use the five headings:

- **Find:** how I'll choose what matters (for example, a weekly review with big rocks, and a daily MIT).
- **Organize:** how I'll plan my time (for example, time blocking each evening, with buffer).
- **Control:** how I'll protect my attention (for example, notifications off, phone in the hallway, checking windows).
- **Use:** how I'll manage my energy (for example, deep work in the morning, 50/10 sessions, bed by 11).
- **Sustain:** how I'll keep it going (for example, starting routine, shutdown ritual, habit tracker, never miss twice).

Keep it short enough to fit on one page. Put it somewhere you'll see it. (Start here and Chapter 20)

Day 30: Commit to a maintenance plan. Look back at your Day 7 baseline and compare it with where you are now: screen time, focus sessions, how you feel about your work. Write a short letter to yourself about what has changed. Then make a plan for the next 30 days: which practices you'll keep, which one new experi-

ment you'll try, and when your next monthly reset will be. Tell one person about your plan. (Chapter 20)

After the challenge

Finishing thirty days doesn't mean your habits are fixed. As you read in Chapter 16, many habits take two months or more to become automatic. Keep going with the practices that worked, keep your weekly reviews, and use your monthly reset to adjust.

If you'd like, repeat the challenge in three or six months. Many people find it works even better the second time, because they know which days matter most for them and can adapt the rest.

The focus toolkit

These are the planning pages and worksheets used throughout the book. If you're reading on a Kindle or phone, copy the questions into a notebook or a notes app. If you have the paperback, you can write straight onto the page or photocopy it for your own use.

Keep them simple. A plan you use every day is worth more than a beautiful one you abandon.

1. The daily focus plan

Use this every evening for tomorrow, or first thing in the morning before you check messages. It takes about ten minutes. (Chapter 10)

> **Date:**
>
> **Fixed commitments today** (classes, meetings, appointments):
>
> **My most important task (MIT):**
>
> **Target for the MIT session** (what "done" looks like):
>
> **Up to two other important tasks:**
>
> **Time blocks** (add 50 percent to each estimate):
>
> - Focus block 1: time, task, target
> - Focus block 2: time, task, target
> - Shallow work window(s): times
> - Breaks and meals: times
> - Buffer: time

One obstacle I can see coming, and my if-then plan for it:

Evening check: Did I do my MIT? What went well? What will I change tomorrow?

2. The focus session log

Fill in one line after each session. Review it weekly. (Chapters 5 and 12)

For each session, note:

- Date and start time
- Length (minutes)
- Task and target
- Target reached? (yes, partly, no)
- Number of times my mind wandered (roughly)
- Main distraction
- Energy level, 1 to 5

Weekly totals: number of completed sessions, total focused minutes, best time of day, most common distraction.

3. The procrastination log

Use this for three days whenever you notice yourself putting something off, and again whenever a task keeps slipping. (Chapter 2)

For each task you avoid, note:

- **The task:**
- **What I did instead:**
- **The feeling it gave me** (in one or two words):
- **Which triggers it hits:** boring, frustrating, difficult, ambiguous, unstructured, no reward, no personal meaning

- **A smaller first step:**
- **When I'll take that step** (as an if-then plan):

4. The screen-time audit

Do this at the start, then once a month to check your progress. (Chapters 3 and 6)

Daily average screen time:

Pickups or unlocks per day:

Notifications per day:

Top five apps by time, and for each one: *What does it give me? What does it cost me?*

1.
2.
3.
4.
5.

The app that costs me most for what it gives:

My rule for that app (delete from phone, log out, checking windows, time limit, grayscale, computer only):

When I usually reach for my phone without a reason:

What I'll do instead in those moments:

5. The digital reset checklist

Work through this once, then check it again at each monthly reset. (Chapter 6)

- Notifications turned off for every app that fails the test "Does a human being need me, right now?"

- Work or study focus mode set up and scheduled
- Sleep mode set up and scheduled
- Time-swallowing apps moved off the home screen
- Worst app deleted from the phone, or logged out after each use
- Grayscale tried for at least one week
- A home for the phone during focus sessions, away from the desk
- Phone charging outside the bedroom, with an alarm clock instead
- Checking windows chosen for social media and non-urgent messages
- Replacements chosen for boredom, waiting, breaks and winding down

6. The if-then planner

Write a plan for each of your most common obstacles. Say each one to yourself once or twice. (Chapter 11)

To start important work: If it is [time, place or event], then I will [small, specific first action].

To handle distraction: If I feel the urge to [distraction], then I will [response].

To handle interruption: If [person] asks me to [request] during my focus time, then I will [response].

To handle low energy: If I'm too tired for my full session, then I will [minimum version].

To recover from a slip: If I miss my habit one day, then the next day I will [minimum version].

7. The WOOP sheet

Use this for a big goal, a week or a single day. It takes about five minutes. (Chapters 4 and 14)

Wish: What do I want to achieve? (Challenging but possible.)

Outcome: What's the best result of achieving it? How will it feel? Picture it for a minute.

Obstacle: What's the main thing inside me that could stop me? Picture it clearly.

Plan: If [obstacle], then I will [action].

8. The goal map

Turn one big goal into milestones and weekly actions. (Chapter 14)

Outcome goal:

Why it matters to me:

Milestones, each with a date:

1.
2.
3.
4.
5.

Process goals for the first milestone (what I'll do every day or week):

My lead measure (what I'll count each week):

Who I'll tell, and when they'll check on me:

Goals I'm putting on the "later" list for now:

9. The weekly review

Thirty to forty-five minutes, at the same time each week. (Chapter 20)

Clear

- Empty capture lists, inbox and notes into one place, and decide on each item: do, schedule, delegate or delete.

- Tidy the desk and the computer desktop.
- Close small open loops.

Review

- Focus sessions completed this week:
- Key habits kept (out of 7 days):
- Screen time, daily average:
- What went well this week?
- What got in the way?
- What will I do differently next week?

FOCUS check: Which letter needs the most attention? Find, Organize, Control, Use or Sustain? One action for it:

Plan

- Big rocks for next week (one to three):
- Time blocked for each:
- Obstacles I can see coming, with an if-then plan for each:

Close

- Monday's MIT:
- Shutdown phrase said. The week is done.

10. The monthly reset

One hour, on the first weekend of each month. (Chapter 20)

- Are my goals still the right ones? Anything to change, drop or move to "later"?
- Did I reach this month's milestone? If not, why, and what's the new date?
- Which habits are now automatic? Which still take effort? Is it time to add one?
- Screen time trend this month, and anything that has crept back:
- Commitments I should step back from:

- One experiment for next month:

11. The habit plan and tracker

Build one habit at a time. (Chapter 16)

The habit:

Habit stack: After I [existing habit], I will [new habit].

Two-minute version:

Minimum version for bad days:

Immediate reward (tracker mark, small celebration or temptation bundle):

Environment change (cue made obvious, friction removed):

Tracker: On a calendar or in your notebook, write the numbers 1 to 30 in a row and cross off each day you do the habit. If you miss a day, circle it and make sure the next number gets crossed. Never miss twice.

12. The shutdown ritual

Ten to fifteen minutes at the end of every workday. (Chapter 17)

1. Check inbox and messages one last time; capture anything that needs doing.
2. Look at tomorrow's calendar and task list.
3. Choose tomorrow's MIT and write it down.
4. Leave a note on any unfinished task: where I stopped and what comes next.
5. Tidy the desk.
6. Say my shutdown phrase:
7. Close the laptop, switch off work notifications, leave the workspace.

13. Which technique should I try?

When something isn't working, find your problem below and try the suggested technique first.

I keep reaching for my phone. Turn off notifications, give the phone a home outside the room, move apps off the home screen, try grayscale. (Chapter 6)

I can't decide where to start. Sort your list with the urgent-important matrix and choose one MIT. (Chapter 9)

The task feels too big. Find the next physical action, or break the task into session-sized steps. (Chapter 11)

I dread starting. Name the feeling, then do a two-minute start or a ten-minute agreement. (Chapters 2 and 11)

I'm afraid it won't be good enough. Write an ugly first draft against a timer, and set a "good enough" standard in advance. (Chapters 4 and 11)

My mind keeps wandering. Use a parking page, notice and name each drift, and try five minutes of breath-focused practice daily. (Chapters 4 and 5)

I keep worrying about other things. Schedule a daily worry time and write worries down when they appear. (Chapter 4)

I can only focus for a few minutes. Start low on the focus ladder and build up slowly. (Chapter 5)

I get interrupted constantly. Batch shallow work, block focus time in your calendar, agree on what's urgent, use a visible signal. (Chapters 8 and 19)

My plans always collapse. Plan less, add 50 percent to estimates, and add buffer blocks. (Chapter 10)

I'm busy all day but nothing important moves. Do your MIT first, before email, and protect one deep work block a day. (Chapters 8 and 9)

I start well and then stop. Shrink the habit, stack it on an existing one, track it, and never miss twice. (Chapters 15 and 16)

One bad day ruins my week. Use the reset routine and the friend test. (Chapter 15)

> **I'm exhausted.** Check sleep, caffeine, breaks and boundaries before anything else. Watch for signs of burnout. (Chapter 17)

Notes and sources

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A note on the evidence

Some techniques in this book, such as if-then plans, retrieval practice and spacing, have been tested in hundreds of studies. Others, such as the Pomodoro Technique, the Eisenhower matrix and time blocking, are widely used frameworks with less direct experimental evidence behind them. They're included because many people find them useful and because they put better-tested principles into practice. Where the evidence for a popular idea is weak or mixed, as with the "brain drain" study in Chapter 6 or the claim that habits take 21 days, the chapter says so.

A small request

If this book helped you take back even one evening, finish one task you'd been avoiding, or put your phone down at one dinner, please leave an honest review wherever you bought it. Reviews are how other readers, the student staring at the same page for an hour and the parent trying to fit a dream into the gaps, find a book like this.

And if you know someone who keeps promising themselves they'll start tomorrow, pass it on.

About the author

Muhammad Waqas writes practical books about the everyday struggles that stand between people and the lives they want. His other books include *The Archer and the Wind: How to Keep Going When Hard Work Isn't Enough* and *AI for Barbershop Owners*.

Focus Is Your Superpower is built around a question almost everyone has asked themselves at some point: "I know what I should be doing. Why can't I make myself do it?" The answer in these pages draws on research into attention, habits and procrastination, and it is written to be used, not just read.